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SAMVAT 2083 BEGINS

Sensex & Nifty Fall in Muhurat Trade First Time Since '17



NITIN SONAWANE

Indian equities closed marginally lower in Muhurat trading that marked the beginning of Samvat 2083, with the Sensex and Nifty recording their first declines on the special Diwali session since 2017. The Sensex ended at 80,999.40, down 28.62 points, or 0.04%, while the Nifty closed at 24,986.40, shedding 43.95 points, or 0.18%, from Friday's close. Both indices had last ended the Muhurat session lower in October 2017, when they fell 0.6% each. ▸▸ 7

COMMON HUB IN MAHANADI BASIN

Gas Hunt RIL, ONGC, BP may Share $1-billion Infra Facility

OilMin's proposal seeks to make deepwater discoveries commercially viable, boost efficiency

Kalpana Pathak

Mumbai: State-run Oil and Natural Gas Corp. (ONGC), BP, and Reliance Industries (RIL) are exploring a $1 billion common offshore infrastructure facility in the Mahanadi basin to get natural gas and condensate from deepwater and ultra-deepwater fields, according to two industry executives.

The proposal mooted by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas is at a preliminary discussion stage, with technical consultants expected to be appointed shortly, the executives added.

The shared infrastructure model aims to reduce development costs, eliminate standalone facilities for smaller discoveries and improve operational efficiency and commercial viability.

ONGC, BP, RIL and the ministry didn't respond to queries.

"The facility is aimed at making deep water and ultra-deepwater discoveries commercially viable by allowing multiple operators to share infrastructure instead of investing in separate facilities, which can significantly increase project costs," said one of the persons cited.

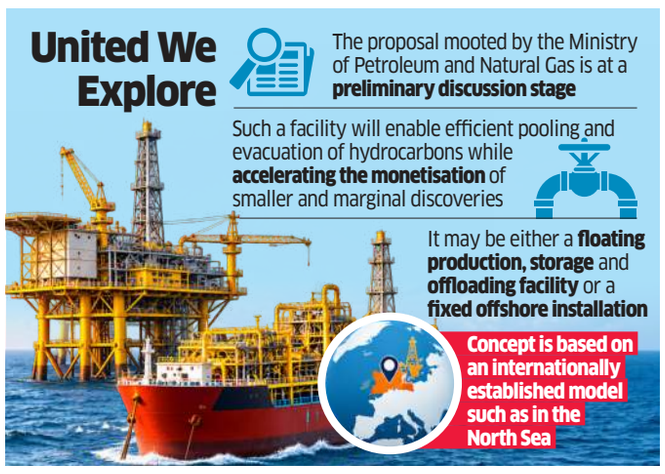
It will also enable efficient pooling and evacuation of hydrocarbons while accelerating the monetisation of smaller and marginal discoveries. The initiative is particularly significant as deepwater and ultra-deepwater environments call for heavy capital expenditure and complex infrastructure requirements, which pose barriers to commercial viability.

It's yet to be decided whether the facility will be a floating production, storage and offloading (FPSO) facility or a fixed offshore installation.

An FPSO-based solution could potentially be brought to the location in a prefabricated form, while a fixed offshore facility could take longer to construct. Developing infrastructure of this scale would take at least three to four years. The facility would primarily handle natural gas, with some condensate also expected to be evacuated.

The concept is based on an internationally established model, with similar shared infrastructure facilities operating in several regions, including the North Sea. Under the arrangement, two or more developers jointly create infrastructure, which can subsequently be used by other producers on a tolling basis.

India has been exploring ways to improve utilisation of existing oil and gas infrastructure and encourage greater collaboration among operators to increase domestic production. The common hub proposal extends this approach to deepwater and ultra-deepwater developments, where infrastructure costs are particularly high.



FEST AND FURIOUS

QComm Decks Up for Diwali and Shoppers Tap Big

Platforms roll out new features and rewards, orders surge on gifting, last-minute purchases

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Quick commerce and food delivery platforms saw a significant surge in orders during the Diwali weekend as consumers used these apps for last-minute shopping, gifting, puja essentials and food orders, industry executives and analysts told ET.

Platforms such as Blinkit, Zepto, Instamart, Amazon Now and Flipkart Minutes revamped their apps for Diwali, introducing interactive interfaces, gamified rewards and other features to drive consumer engagement and orders.

The trend extended to food delivery platforms such as Zomato, Swiggy and Ownly, while Bistro and Swish offered curated product selections like chaat platters, snack combos and festive meals for Diwali parties to encourage consumers to order in.

The demand surge led to longer delivery timelines and unavailability of riders in some pin codes over the weekend, especially in north Indian cities, executives said. Some platforms such as Blinkit also levied surge charges on smaller orders and increased the threshold for free delivery in busy pin codes.

Amazon Now has seen strong festive demand, said a company spokesperson.

"Diwali essentials led demand, from clay diyas and puja essentials to mithai, chocolates and gift hampers," the person said. "Customers are also adding healthier treats alongside traditional sweets, with sugar-free and no-added-sugar products gaining share across hampers, sweets and nutrition bars."

Gains Momentum ▸▸ 7



PUREPOLITICS

Armed Maoists Gone, Next Target is 'Dimagi Naxals': Modi

Targeting his political opponents, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the threat of Naxalism has not ended even though armed Maoists have been eliminated, alleging that "dimagi Naxals" have infiltrated several organisations, including political parties, and are instigating people against the Constitution and democracy. ▸▸ 2

■ SP, Cong Spreading Narrative Against Ayodhya: Yogi ▸▸ 2

■ Shivakumar Seeks TN Support for Mekedatu Project ▸▸ 2

Agitation Against CEC to Continue : Congress' Venugopal

AICC general secretary KC Venugopal on Sunday said the Congress-led agitation against CEC Gyanesh Kumar would continue until he was removed and the country's electoral system was made impartial and transparent. Venugopal said protests were continuing across states and districts, with only a brief pause expected during the Diwali festival. ▸▸ 2

GOOD OPPORTUNITY FOR INSURERS, BUT COMPETITION COULD CAP PREMIUMS

Under Attack, Banks Bolster Cyber Covers

Opt for higher sum assured to protect against disruptions, financial hit

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: Large financial services companies are seeking to expand their cyber insurance cover amid rising frequency of cyberattacks and increasing cost of business disruption, even as competition among insurers keeps premiums under pressure.

A large non-bank financial company plans to buy a cyber insurance policy of ₹2,000 crore next month, up from ₹1,400 crore last year, according to an insurance industry executive familiar with the placement. The increase reflects concerns that even a temporary disruption to technology systems could result in a substantial financial loss.

"We are seeing increasing interest in higher cyber insurance limits, particularly among large banks, NBFCs and financial institutions," said Najm Bilgrami, head of Casualty and Financial Lines Product at Tata AIG.

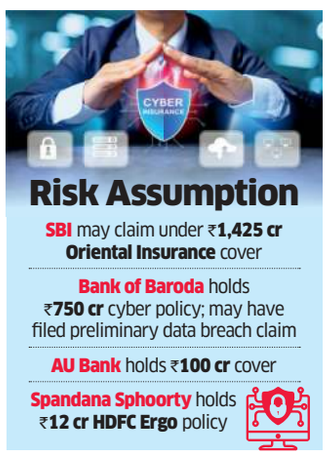
Growing digital dependence and interconnected systems are prompting companies to reassess their covers, he said. "Cyber risk is now viewed as a board-level risk, resulting in greater focus on balance sheet protection against severe cyber events," said Amarnath Saxena, chief technical officer, commercial, at Bajaj General Insurance.

BUSINESS INTERRUPTION

For large financial institutions, the biggest impact often is the loss arising from systems remaining unavailable after an attack, rather than the immediate cost of the breach.

Besides business interruption, ransomware, data theft, cyber extortion and third-party liabilities are among the key risks.

Ambiguity in Wordings ▸▸ 7



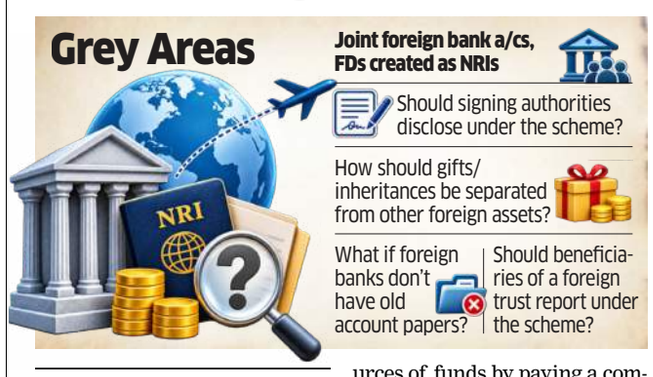
SURGING DEMAND FOR UNSECURED CREDIT

Digi Lenders' Revenue Up 50%

Listed new-age fintech companies reported 40-50% growth in lending and financial services revenue in the September quarter, driven by strong disbursements and rising demand for unsecured credit from younger borrowers. ▸▸ 5

DECLARATION ONCE ACCEPTED CAN'T BE CHANGED

Taxpayers Fret Over Loose Ends in Amnesty Scheme



Seek CBDT clarity on foreign asset disclosure rules as Dec 31 deadline nears

Sugata Ghosh

Mumbai: Many are knocking on the doors of tax authorities to cut through the confusion over a list of ambiguities in the mini-amnesty scheme for undisclosed foreign assets and income.

Will a taxpayer who is merely a signing authority for a foreign bank account but doesn't own the funds get caught in the tax net after declaring as a signatory? How to segregate gifts and inheritances from other foreign assets which were acquired? Or, what if a foreign bank no longer has the statements of accounts which were opened years ago?

Questions like these and more are cropping up as the December 31 deadline nears for the Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme, 2026 (FAST-DS), a one-time compliance initiative.

The voluntary disclosure window, which opened on August 16, allows a person to regularise undeclared overseas stocks, properties, ESOPs, and earnings up to ₹1 crore without declaring sources of funds by paying a combined tax and penalty of 60%. Foreign assets up to ₹5 cr acquired with reported earnings can be legitimised with a ₹1 lakh fine.

Despite the tax office responding to FAQs, taxpayers and professionals want the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) to clarify several unaddressed issues.

For instance, how to avoid tax and penalties on the quantum of bank deposits accumulated from the overseas earnings of a declarant when he was an NRI? Since NRIs' foreign earnings aren't taxed in India, deposits created from that income should not be taxed and penalised.

After Dec 31, non-declarants may face a higher financial burden if faced with proceedings under Black Money Act

Those who missed out on reporting, either due to ignorance or wrong advice, are anxious for answers. A declaration, once accepted, cannot be changed; the amount paid will not be refunded, and false information will invalidate the declaration. After December 31, persons who don't declare under FAST-DS may face a higher financial burden if faced with proceedings under Black Money Act.

Ownership vs Authority ▸▸ 7

Inside story

Govt Prepares Norms to Extend ZED Scheme to Services Sector

The government has prepared a framework to expand its Zero Defect Zero Effect (ZED) certification scheme to the services sector, extending its quality improvement and competitiveness initiative beyond manufacturing to micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs). The MSME ministry has identified 20 parameters to assess service enterprises on quality benchmarks. ▸▸ 4

GSec Volatility Adds Uncertainty to Banks' Accounting Transition Costs

Fluctuations in government bond yields are emerging as a fresh uncertainty for Indian banks preparing to adopt the new accounting framework from April 1, 2027. Several lenders have revised their estimated transition costs, while others are yet to quantify the additional impact of valuing held-to-maturity (HTM) investment portfolios at market prices. ▸▸ 4

Coal India, IRP Seek No Sops to Make Rare Earth Magnets

Govt opens financial bids under scheme; other contenders include ReNew, Prozeal

Twesh Mishra and Shilpa Samant

New Delhi: The heavy industries ministry has opened financial bids under the scheme to set up rare earth permanent magnet manufacturing facilities in the country. Officials said state-owned Coal India has sought a nil per kg incentive.

Hyderabad-based IRP Infratech consortium with US-headquartered BaRupOn has also sought zero per kilogram production-linked incentive under the central scheme. Prozeal, ReNew, and Midwest have sought per-kg incentives ranging from ₹243 to ₹505 under the scheme.

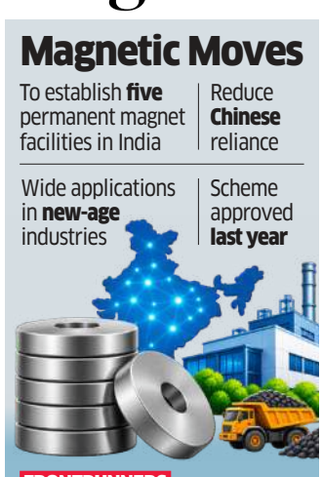
India is the world's third-largest rare earth resource-rich country. Calls to harness them intensified after China curbed exports of REPM in April 2025, threatening supply chains across industries.

A ₹7,280 crore scheme to promote manufacturing of sintered Rare Earth Permanent Magnet (REPM) was approved in November last year. The ministry of heavy industries (MHI) is offering a ₹150 crore capital subsidy and a per kg sale incentive of up to ₹2,150 under the scheme aimed to reduce import dependence.

Responding to queries from ET, Midwest Energy said it has bid ₹505.05 per kg with a cap of 1200 tonnes per annum (TPA) plus ₹150 crore as capital expenditure incentive. "Midwest is an early entrant with a phase-I plant with a capacity of 500 TPA, which is under commissioning with planned expansion to cover 1200 TPA to be completed by August, 2027," the company said.

Prozeal Green Energy bid ₹243 per kg, while ReNew Power bid ₹449 per kg.

In August, MHI said it had received 20 bids through a global tender. Of these, 16 qualified after the technical round.



FCNR Interest to Keep Costs High for USD Hedging

A multibillion-dollar FCNR(B) interest bill, coupled with the Reserve Bank of India's new reserve requirement on forex derivatives, is likely to keep dollar hedging costlier for Indian banks, treasury executives said. ▸▸ 7

Agri Loans Now Biggest Risk to Asset Quality

Agricultural loans have emerged as the biggest asset-quality risk for banks, with the segment's bad-loan ratio far exceeding industry, services and retail despite a broader improvement in loan books, reports **Sangita Mehta**. ▸▸ 8

When Not Hiking Prices So Much is Also a Celebration

Consumer goods firms turn to cost cutting measures amid higher input costs to protect demand and revive volume growth

Writankar Mukherjee & Aanya Thakur

Kolkata | Mumbai: Consumer goods companies are increasingly absorbing rising raw material costs rather than resorting to blanket price hikes, seeking to protect demand and sustain recovery in volume growth.

These companies, such as ITC, Hindustan Unilever, Godrej Consumer Products, Emami, Havells, Reliance Retail and Aditya Birla Lifestyle Brands, are combining selective price increases with cost-cutting measures to limit the impact on consumers as well as their own margins.

This strategy comes amid an elevated input-cost outlook flagged by several companies during recent earnings calls, due to high raw material prices, supply disruptions and freight charges. They are cutting trade investments as well as rationalising vendor networks to negotiate better rates through higher volumes. Part of the impact is absorbed into their margins.

Godrej Consumer Products chief executive Asif Malbari said inflation across crude oil-linked derivatives, palm oil and other commodities intensified last quarter, resulting in a high single-digit rise in input costs, one of the highest increases in raw material costs in several years.

Despite a significant part of its portfolio comprising fixed-price packs, the company took stringent pricing actions alongside cost-saving measures and optimisation of trade investments, Malbari told analysts.

Retailers and apparel makers are also balancing pricing actions with cost-saving initiatives. Reliance Retail, the country's largest retail chain, started absorbing part of the input cost increase to protect demand. Its chief financial officer Dinesh Taluja said inflation was at a two-year high, weighing on consumers' purchasing power.

The company is identifying areas of high customer demand, working with fewer vendors in those markets and undertaking joint business planning to improve margins rather than raising prices, he said.

Aditya Birla Lifestyle Brands managing director Ashish Dikshit said the company offset cost increases through a 6% price increase, with a larger portion of the additional costs not passed on to consumers.

"We have worked very closely with our vendor partners to be able to minimise the increase from that," he said.



HIGH-VALUE BRACKETS REMAIN FLAT

Mid-Clients Grow Fast for Top IT

India's top nine IT services firms are seeing faster growth in smaller client accounts with $1 million or more in annual revenue rising at most firms in the first half of FY27. ▸▸ 5

CONTINUING HIS NARRATIVE FROM I-DAY SPEECH

Armed Maoists Gone, Next Target is 'Dimagi Naxals': PM



PM Modi during a Diwali celebration programme with the security forces at Karanpur's CoBRA Operations Base, in Bastar on Sunday. –ANI

INFILTRATION IN ORGANISATIONS

Naxalites have been eliminated, but the threat is not over yet. Armed Naxalites have disappeared from forests, but 'dimagi Naxals' have taken control of several organisations

PTI

Jagdalpur: Targeting his political opponents, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the threat of Naxalism has not ended even though armed Maoists have been eliminated, alleging that "dimagi Naxals" have infiltrated several organisations, including political parties, and are instigating people against the Constitution and democracy.

"We must identify and defeat such elements and secure the country," Modi said, addressing security personnel while celebrating Diwali at a Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) camp in Karanpur in Chhattisgarh's Bastar district.

The central armed police forces and personnel of the Chhattisgarh Police have been deployed in Bastar. They were deeply involved in the anti-Naxal operations. On March 31 this year, the Centre had announced that India was free from the menace of Naxalism after the elimination of many leaders and cadres and the surrender of hundreds of others.

Modi said the elimination of Maoist terror was a victory of the country's right policies and strong political will. "Amid the successes, we must remember one more thing. Naxalites have been eliminated, but the threat is not over yet. Armed Naxalites have disappeared from the forests, but 'dimagi Naxals' (a reference to ideological supporters of Naxalites) have taken control of several organisations," he said.

"Even today, they are instigating people against the country's Constitution and democracy. They have infiltrated several political parties and different organisations. We must identify and defeat them and secure the country," he added.

Earlier, in his address on the 80th Independence Day, the PM had referred to "dimagi Naxals", saying the ideological supporters of armed Naxalism were seeking to promote violence and anarchy.

'PM DESPERATE'

'Jhola picking-up Time' is Fast Approaching for Modi: Congress

PTI

New Delhi: The Congress on Sunday hit back at Prime Minister Narendra Modi after his "dimagi Naxals" jibe at political rivals, saying he is clearly distraught, disturbed and desperate, and his "jhola-picking-up time" is fast approaching.

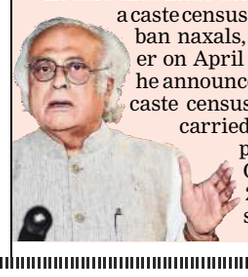
The party's dig came after Modi targeted political opponents, saying armed Maoists have been eliminated, but "dimagi Naxals" have infiltrated several organisations and are instigating people against the Constitution and democracy.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said the PM has not spared the nation even on Diwali day his "trademark abuse".

"He has once again spoken of what he calls 'dimagi naxals'. He has used a very solemn non-political occasion, donned the uniform of the security forces, and hurled invectives at his political rivals," Ramesh said on X.

This is a brazen assault on all institutional norms but when has that ever stopped this man, he asked.

It was on April 28, 2024 that he said that those demanding a caste census were urban naxals, and later on April 30, 2025, he announced that a caste census will be carried out as part of Census 2027, he said.



CONGRESS TO LAUNCH 'VOTE BACHAO, DESH BACHAO' CAMPAIGN AT THE PANCHAYAT LEVEL

Nov 1 Protest was Strongest Show of Strength... Agitation against CEC to Continue: Congress

PTI

Alappuzha : AICC general secretary KC Venugopal on Sunday said the Congress-led agitation against CEC Gyanesh Kumar would continue until he was removed from the post and the country's electoral system was made impartial and transparent.

Speaking to reporters here, Venugopal said protests were continuing across states and districts, with only a brief pause expected during the Diwali festival.

He described the November 1 rally organised by the Congress in New Delhi as one of the strongest protests witnessed in the country, saying the party was fighting against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah.

"We will withdraw from this agitation only after Gyanesh Kumar is removed from the post and steps are taken to make India's electoral system and processes flawless, impartial and fair. This is not a struggle that we will abandon midway," he said.

Venugopal alleged that the deletion of names from electoral rolls would deprive poor people of their voting rights and access to various government benefits, which, he claimed, were increasingly being linked to voter identity cards.

We will withdraw from this agitation only after Gyanesh Kumar is removed from the post and steps are taken to make India's electoral system and processes flawless, impartial and fair. This is not a struggle that we will abandon midway
KC VENUGOPAL
General secretary, AICC

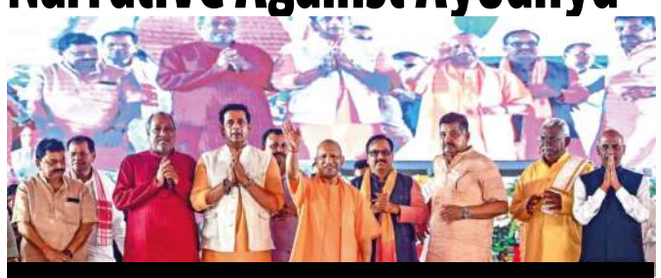


He said the Congress would launch a nationwide 'Vote Bachao, Desh Bachao' (Save the Vote, Save the Nation) campaign at the panchayat level over the next one-and-a-half months.

As part of the campaign, the party would appoint a 'Vote Rakshak' (guardian) in every polling booth to scrutinise electoral rolls, identify people whose names had been deleted and visit their homes to help them get their names restored, he said.

Congress units were organising programmes across states and districts, while plans were also being drawn up for joint programmes with other political parties, he said. Venugopal said the issue would be strongly raised during the upcoming Parliament session, adding that the Opposition would take up recent controversies and issues affecting the public.

Yogi: SP, Congress Spreading Narrative Against Ayodhya



UP CM Yogi Adityanath with BJP MP Ravi Kishan during the Deepotsav celebrations at Vantangiya village in Gorakhpur on Sunday– IANS

PTI

Gorakhpur: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday accused the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Congress of "spreading propaganda" against Ayodhya, claiming that the ongoing journey of heritage preservation and development in the state would eventually threaten the political existence of the two opposition parties. Addressing a Diwali programme for the Van Tangiya community at Jungle Tinkonia in Gorakhpur, Adityanath said the opposition parties were uncomfortable with the development of Ayodhya and the infrastructure projects being undertaken in the state.

"People are now maligning Ayodhya out of fear. They are spreading propaganda against Ayodhya because they know that if this journey of heritage and development continues in the same manner, the politics of the Samajwadi Party and the Congress will be buried forever," he said.

"Those who once created an identity crisis for the state will now face a crisis of their own political identity. If this journey continues with the same strength and unity, the Congress and the Samajwadi Party will themselves face an identity crisis," he added.

MEKEDATU BALANCING RESERVOIR

K'taka to Proceed with Project, DK Seeks TN's Help

Shivakumar says SC had already upheld the state's right to build the Mekedatu project

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday said Karnataka would move ahead with the proposed Mekedatu balancing reservoir project, asserting that the Supreme Court had already upheld the state's right to build the project subject to Cauvery water-sharing obligations.

Seeking cooperation from Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay, Shivakumar said Karnataka did not need to seek fresh permission from any state. "The Supreme Court has already allowed Karnataka to build the reservoir at its own site, subject to releasing 177 tmc ft of water to Tamil Nadu," he told reporters.

He said the project would benefit both states by regulating river flows and improving water management, adding that Karnataka had identified around 5,400 acres of land for compensatory afforestation and would soon submit the application after completing the process.

Stressing that Karnataka was united on the issue, he said leaders across party lines, including those from the BJP and NDA, had backed the state's position. "There is no question of conflict. The Supreme Court has delivered its verdict. We must respect the law and work together to share water," he said, inviting Tamil Nadu to send a delegation to review the project.

The remarks came a day after Tamil Nadu CM Joseph Vijay wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressing concern over reports that Union government officials had conducted a site inspection linked to the Mekedatu proposal. Vijay urged the Centre not to grant statutory or administrative approvals without the consent of co-basin states.

In his letter, Vijay said the reported inspection had heightened concerns among farmers in the Cauvery delta, particularly in a deficit water year. He alleged Karnataka had failed to ensure Tamil Nadu's due share of Cauvery water and stressed that the rights of lower riparian states, including the quantum and monthly pattern of water releases, must remain protected.

'KTR Drove Sister Out, will He Do Good to People?'

Telangana chief minister Revanth Reddy says his government aims to expand number of Self Help Group members in the state to one crore from the current 70 lakh, distributes 'Indiramma' sarees

PTI

Hyderabad: Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy on Sunday accused BRS leader KT Rama Rao of driving his sister, K Kavitha, out of the family home over his unwillingness to share family property.

Addressing a meeting of woman Self-Help Group (SHG) members in his assembly constituency of Kodangal, he also said the total number of SHG members now stands at 70 lakh which the government now aims to expand it to one crore by 2034.

He said the government would launch the second phase of distribution of free 'Indiramma' sarees to women on November 19 on the occasion of birth anniversary of former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi.

"I am trying to show my gratitude to you by distributing 'Indiramma' sarees as a brother's gift. But, see KTR. Not ready to share family property, he drove his sister (TRS president Kavitha) out of the home. The sister who returned after a serving a jail term, facing cases," he said, referring to Kavitha serving a jail term in connection with the case related to Delhi liquor policy and her subsequent suspension from BRS.

Kavitha has floated her own outfit Telangana Rakshana Sena (TRS).

"Whatever is (her) mistake, he should take care of the sister when she comes home after spending about six months in jail. But, is there anyone else on the earth, except KCR's son, who drove his own sister out of the home, saying she committed mistakes and sold liquor," Reddy said.

Referring to Rama Rao's comments on BRS working for women's welfare, he asked whether the BRS leader's comments are trustworthy as he has mistreated his sister.

Whatever is (her) mistake, he should take care of the sister when she comes home after spending about six months in jail. But, is there anyone else on the earth, except KCR's son, who drove his own sister out of the home, saying she committed mistakes and sold liquor
A REVANTH REDDY
Chief minister, Telangana



Without mentioning her name, he said Kavitha herself made critical comments against Rama Rao.

Taking aim at BRS president K Chandrasekhar Rao (KCR), Reddy said father is expected to advise his son to take good care of his sister which he has failed to do.

"The person (KCR) who cannot teach good things to his family members, will he do good to four crore Telangana people," Reddy said. KCR meted out a raw deal to the state when he was CM for 10 years, he said.

Reddy, who celebrated his birthday on Sunday, said he had served as Zilla Parishad member, MLC, MLA, MP and now serving as Chief Minister. He said there is nothing he can aspire for in his life and that his goal now is transform one crore women intro 'crorepatis'.

Reservoir of Woes



DK's Stand

SC allowed Karnataka to build reservoir at its own site, subject to releasing 177 tmc ft of water to Tamil Nadu

Project would benefit both states by regulating river flows and improving water management

Vijay's Concerns

Vijay had urged Centre not to grant statutory or administrative approvals without the consent of co-basin states



He alleged that inspection had heightened concerns among farmers in the Cauvery delta

ET GRAPHICS

Punjab's Choking

Despite the dipping Air Quality Index (AQI) in the Delhi-NCR region and worsening breathing conditions, the stubble burning crisis continues to remain a challenge for the administration, as despite multiple warnings and reminders, the incidents continue to be reported, with as many as 200 in Punjab's Patiala district alone. Thiis is what a report by the Punjab Pollution Control Board (PPCB) states:



FIRs Registered

Total FIRs registered **870** FIRs

Red entries recorded in **1,004** CASES

Warning notices **1,102**

Incidents Rising

3,307 Stubble burning incidents recorded in Punjab till November 7

2,903 Sites inspected

Burning of crop residue confirmed at **1,275** LOCATIONS

Fines

Fine imposed **₹60.60** LAKH

What has been recovered **₹32.50** LAKH

Patiala: The Worst Hit

City administration registered	Incidents of stubble burning	Sites were inspected	Stubble burning confirmed
77 FIRs	196	157	94 LOCATIONS

Source: IANS

VASU

E20 DEBATE WIDENS

Karnataka to Reveal Probe Findings Today; MoS Suresh Gopi backs OMCs

Govt had taken serious note of complaints over petrol containing ethanol levels of up to 31.5%: DK

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday said the Karnataka government will disclose more details on the alleged excess ethanol-blending issue on Monday, even as Kerala ordered laboratory tests on petrol samples. Oil marketing companies (OMCs) have denied Karnataka's charges and called for joint and transparent testing.

Speaking to reporters, Shivakumar said samples had been collected from 67 locations across the state and Food and Civil Supplies Minister Rizwan Arshad would present the inspection report and outline the government's next course of action on Monday.

The CM said the government had taken serious note of complaints over petrol allegedly containing ethanol levels of up to 31.5%, well above the mandated blend.

Karnataka has informed the Centre and directed the concerned department to investigate the issue, he added.

"Thousands of motorists have complained of reduced mileage, shorter travel distances and vehicles stalling while in motion," he said.

He said inspection teams examined not only retail fuel outlets but also facilities involved in ethanol blending and distribution.

Officials have collected records detailing where and how blending was carried out, and a comprehensive report will be made public, he added.

The CM said the Centre could not "shirk responsibility" on an issue involving fuel quality, vehicle performance and public safety. He criticised any move to increase blending ratios purely to take advantage of lower ethanol costs, saying public inconvenience could not be justified.

Meanwhile, Union Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi defended the Centre's ethanol-blending programme, saying the decision to allow 20% ethanol blending (E20) was backed by scientific studies and technical assessments. He said any future increase in blending levels would also be based on scientific feasibility and warned against politicising technical issues.

Kerala's Food and Civil Supplies Department has ordered testing of petrol samples from four districts.

The three state-run OMCs have, however, rejected Karnataka's claim that petrol sold at some retail outlets contained 26-31% ethanol. The companies said the findings were not based on prescribed testing procedures and could not be independently verified.

'CENTRE HAS SCIENTIFIC BACKING FOR ETHANOL-BLENDING POLICY'

Karnataka, Kerala Free to Test Petrol for Ethanol Content; Don't Politicise Issue: MoS Suresh Gopi



Thrissur: Union MoS Suresh Gopi on Sunday said the Karnataka and Kerala governments were free to test petrol samples to ascertain their ethanol content but cautioned against politicising the issue. His remarks came after the Karnataka government claimed that tests conducted by it had detected higher ethanol content in petrol supplied at fuel stations. The Kerala government also decided on Saturday to conduct similar tests. Responding to reporters, the Union Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas said both governments were free to conduct the tests, asserting that the Centre had scientific backing for its ethanol-blending policy. –PTI

DENYING KARNATAKA'S CLAIMS

The 3 state-run OMCs have said findings were not based on prescribed testing procedures and could not be independently verified

Officials Demanding Hefty Bribes to Clear Files, Claims HDK



PTI

Hassan: Union minister HD Kumaraswamy on Sunday alleged that officials in Hassan district were demanding large sums of money to clear files and facilitate official work. Addressing a press conference here, he released what he described as 15 pages of WhatsApp conversations, which he claimed pointed to demands for money to clear crusher-related files and land conversion proposals. Reading out an excerpt from one of the purported conversations, Kumaraswamy said: "Your job is that of a broker, isn't it? We have to pay the amount you give us to officials. From the small amount left over, I have to distribute it among everyone in my section. The driver, gunman, another personal assistant and everyone else have to be paid."

He alleged ₹60 lakh was demanded to clear three crusher-related files, of which ₹50 lakh was meant for the senior official concerned and ₹10 lakh for distribution among other staff. He referred to alleged payments for land conversion and other official work as well. ₹75 lakh had been paid to ensure that an official continued in a particular post, Kumaraswamy alleged. He read out a purported WhatsApp message in which the sender claimed to have arranged the money from different sources and handed it over through an intermediary.

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FSSAI Seizes 3,280 tonnes of Banned Products, Cancels 52 Licences Since Sept 1



PTI

New Delhi: The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has seized 3,280 tonnes of 'banned and non-compliant' food products worth ₹82 crore during its nationwide inspection drive, which began on September 1 to check for adulteration during the festive season.

Acting against food safety violations, the FSSAI cancelled 52 licences, suspended 1,133 licences, and sealed 314 establishments.

In a social media post on Saturday, the FSSAI said that it has stepped up vigilance in view of festivals.

The regulator said it inspected 56,431 food establishments during its nationwide enforcement drive between September 1 and November 5, and seized non-compliant food products, including paneer, ghee, milk and sweets.

A total of 3,279.57 tonnes of 'banned and non-compliant' food products worth ₹81.80 crore were seized, it said.

Additionally, the regulator issued 10,047 improvement notices to food business operators.

This calendar year, the FSSAI has stepped up enforcement actions against food business operators and e-commerce companies to ensure safe food for consumers.

Subaru, Toyota Pick Perfect Time to Roll Out Affordable EVs

Bloomberg

Karla Fisher, a Marine and retired engineer, arguably should have bought an electric vehicle a year ago.

There were federal incentives and a crowd of options, including the Ford F-150 Lightning, Honda Prologue and Nissan Ariya — all of which have since disappeared.

But none of those vehicles quite met Fisher's specific requirements: at least seven inches of ground clearance, more than 250 miles of range and a price in line with — or slightly below — that of gas-burning alternatives. The Subaru Trailseeker, a new model that hit the market early this year, checked all the boxes. Fisher bought hers in September and already has put 2,000 miles on it, driving to trailheads, fishing holes and campsites near her home on the Oregon coast.

"I have been watching the EV market for more than a decade," she said. "Alas, no cars were produced that made sense to me as a consumer in all that time." The battery-powered Subaru, she attests, is now her "most favorite car of all time."

As US auto executives cooled on electric cars this year, scrapping models and cutting production, Subaru Corp. and Toyota Motor Corp. nosed into the void. With five new models, the companies have collectively sold almost 62,000 EVs in the US in the first three quarters of 2026, more than double their year-earlier tally.

Though the brands still represent only 9% of the US EV market and trail General Motors Co. in the space, their sales are growing, while rivals have gone in reverse. In the year to date, Rivian Automotive Inc., which also added a new truck, is the only other carmaker to post a gain in battery-powered business.

Subaru and Toyota are relatively late to the electric-car race, but their timing is propitious. While EV demand cooled when federal incentives expired in September, the market has stabilized and the ranks of electric-curious drivers are growing.

Analysts say the two brands are scooping up drivers addled by high gas prices and market share that might have otherwise gone to larger rivals who scrapped EV models.

Kirloskar Inds Q2 Profit Rises 5%

New Delhi: Kirloskar Industries (KIL) has reported a 5% rise in consolidated profit after tax (PAT) of ₹105 crore for the quarter ended September 30, 2026. The company had posted consolidated PAT of ₹100.1 crore in the corresponding period last year.

The consolidated income of the company during second quarter rose to ₹2,097.7 crore from ₹1,790.1 crore in the year-ago period, KIL said in a statement. "Our material subsidiary, Kirloskar Ferrous Industries, continued to deliver a resilient performance during the year, supported by operational stability, capacity optimisation and strong demand for its products across the sectors. On the real estate front, our wholly-owned subsidiary, Avante Spaces (ASL), is progressing well. —PTI

Chinese Firms Offering Services to Indian Arms Exempt from Tax

Delhi ITAT order cites India-China tax treaty, experts say ruling does not imply general relief

Vinod Mahanta

Mumbai: Chinese companies that provide management, technical and consultancy services to Indian subsidiaries from overseas are exempt from Indian taxation, the Delhi income tax appellate tribunal (ITAT) has held. The ruling, however, differs from that of the Mumbai bench of the tribunal in 2010, and cannot yet be considered settled law, said tax experts.

In a recent case involving Benteler Automotive (China) Investment, the Delhi ITAT ruled that payments for services rendered entirely in China would not qualify as fees for technical services (FTS) under Article 12(4) of the India-China tax treaty only because they were used in India.

The latest ruling may help Chinese corporations that offer centralised management, engineering and technical assistance to Indian operations. Tax experts pointed out that it was limited to the text of the India-China treaty and did not offer a general exemption for international service providers. They also cited the ambiguity created by the conflicting rulings of the two benches.

Benteler, a Chinese tax resident, provided management, consultancy and technical services to its Indian group company. It was undisputed that the services were rendered from China and that the company had no permanent establishment (PE) in India.



The tribunal held that Article 12(4) required such services to be rendered in India to qualify as FTS. Since these services were performed outside the country, the condition was not met, the tribunal ruled, and allowed Benteler's appeals for assessment years 2015-16 to 2017-18.

"Delhi tribunal's ruling is an important development for Chinese companies providing services to India, particularly in today's digital environment, where services are increasingly delivered remotely across jurisdictions," said Hitesh Sawhney, partner, Price Waterhouse & Co LLP. "The ruling draws an important distinction between where services are performed and where they are utilised, and indicates that the mere utilisation of services in India may not, by itself, result in taxation under the India-China tax treaty."

Under Section 9(1)(vii) of the income-tax Act, FTS can be deemed to accrue in India even when services are performed overseas, if they are used in India. However, a more beneficial tax treaty provision can prevail under section 90.

The ruling differs from the Mumbai ITAT's 2010 decision in a case involving Ashapura Minichem. The appellate tribunal held that payments to a Chinese company for services performed abroad but used in India could be taxed as FTS. It relied on Article 12(6) of India-China tax treaty, which deems such income to arise in India if the payer is an Indian resident or the payment is borne by an Indian PE or fixed base.

The interplay between Article 12 (4), which defines FTS, and article 12(6), which determines where the income is deemed to arise, is central to the dispute. The Delhi tribunal's order interprets Article 12(4) but does not separately analyse Article 12(6).

Chartistry

AVIATION

Fuel to The Fare

THE HIGHLIGHT

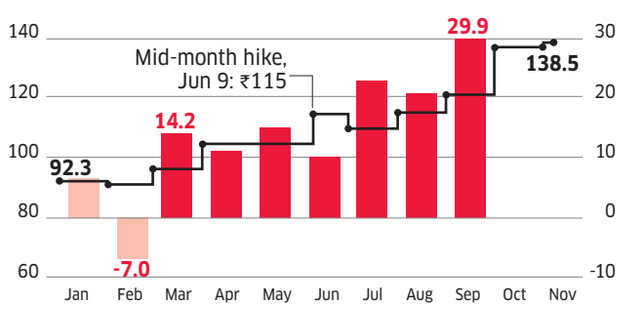
Jet fuel now costs 50% more than it did in January. The airfare inflation rate, too, neared 30% at last count, after turning sharply higher in March.

THE CONTEXT

A petitioner recently approached the Supreme Court, lamenting the rapidly rising cost of air travel. **The court denied an urgent hearing**, saying, "Don't travel by air."

Jet Fuel Price and Airfare Inflation

Since the start of 2026



ATF price is for domestic airlines, and is revised on the 1st of each month (and was also revised mid-month on June 9). Inflation data not available since Sep 2026.

Source: Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, PTI reports

Data: Anna Catherine Jijo; Design: Samir Kumar

LAYING A STRONG FOUNDATION

Kotak Advisors' Realty Fund Plans to Raise ₹4,500 crore

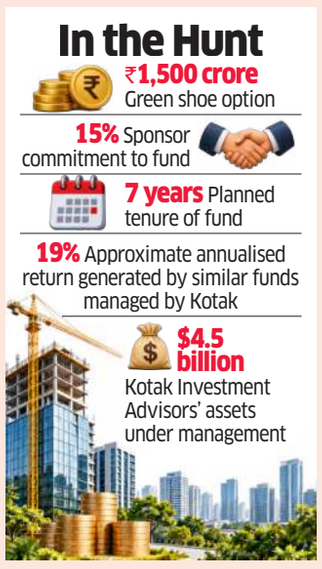
Seeks to deploy a mix of equity and debt in residential and commercial properties

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: Kotak Investment Advisors, the alternative asset management arm of Kotak Mahindra Group, is looking to raise ₹4,500 crore through its 16th real estate fund as it seeks to deploy institutional capital across India's expanding realty market through investments in residential, commercial and alternative property assets with a combination of debt and equity.

The target size of the fund, Kotak Real Estate Fund XIV, includes a green shoe option of ₹1,500 crore and a sponsor commitment of 15%. The fund's tenure will be seven years with provisions for two one-year extensions. It will have an investment period of three-and-a-half years.

"We will follow a hybrid strategy, investing in both debt and equity with no set allocation. We will look at opportunities across market cycles, providing growth capital to developers during expansion phases and addressing liquidity mismatches when needed. The timing and nature of investments will depend on the requirements of developers and the return potential of individual transactions," Vikas Chimakurthy, CEO of Realty Funds, Kotak Alternate Asset Managers, told ET.



The fund expects to undertake 15-20 transactions while retaining flexibility to participate in larger or smaller transactions depending on the return thresholds.

Its primary geographical focus will be Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad, Pune, Mumbai and Kolkata, along with potential opportunities in select tier-II cities.

"Residential real estate is expected to contribute significantly to the portfolio's value creation, given the size of the market. At the same time, we will evaluate opportunities across retail, hospitality, industrial and warehousing, depending on the risk-return profile of individual transactions," Chimakurthy said.

Prior to this, similar funds managed by the firm have generated internal rates of return (IRR) of around 19%. Kotak Investment Advisors has assets under management (AUM) of around $4.5 billion and reported zero credit losses since 2009, past the global financial crisis, the Covid-19 pandemic, and the NBFC crisis.

Developers are turning to organised institutional capital for their funding requirements instead of relying on informal lending from high-net-worth individuals or capital markets, particularly amid subdued performance of recent initial public offerings .

Rising land acquisition and construction costs due to inflation are among the factors the fund will need to consider while evaluating investment opportunities. Institutional investments in India's real estate sector reached $4.4 billion during the first half of calendar year 2026, registering a 25% year-on-year increase, according to JLL. The period recorded 54 transactions, the highest number in a half-year period.

Kalpataru to Achieve ₹6,500cr Pre-sales Target for FY27, says CFO

PTI

New Delhi: Realty firm Kalpataru will achieve its ₹6,500 crore pre-sales target this fiscal, a 23% rise from the previous year, as housing demand remains strong for established players, a senior company official said.

In an interview with PTI, Mumbai-based Kalpataru CFO Chandrashekhar Joglekar said the company's sales bookings or pre-sales stood flat at nearly ₹2,600 crore in the first half of this fiscal.

He noted that housing demand remains "intact" despite concerns about a possible slowdown due to global economic uncertainties.

"We have given guidance for pre-sales at ₹6,500 crore. We have already achieved 40% in the first half of this fiscal. We will be achieving 60% in the second half of this fiscal," Joglekar said. During the first half of this fiscal, the company's sales bookings stood at ₹2,587 crore against ₹2,577 crore in the year-ago period.

Joglekar said the housing sales are generally high in the second half because of festive demand and expressed confidence that the company would comfortably achieve the target. During the 2025-26 fiscal, Kalpataru sales bookings stood at ₹5,280 crore.

Airlines Take the Premium Route to Improve Profits

AFP



HIGH FLYING

Since 2020, number of premium seats on US flights has risen 33%, more than double the growth of mainline seats

Airlines are installing deluxe seats, enlisting Michelin-star chefs for luxury menu offerings and designing elite airport lounges as the industry bets its future on growing demand for premium travel.

The strategy is expected to accelerate the shrinking share of coach class on many flights, with airlines envisioning as much as 70% of passengers paying for enhanced options, if not first-or business class.

Airlines face significantly higher jet fuel costs due to the Iran war, but view such upselling as a profitable longterm bet.

Business class seats can each take up floor space equivalent to four basic-level seats, but can be priced five or six times higher, said Volodymyr Bilotka, a professor at Purdue University and a specialist in aviation economics.

"Airlines have traditionally been investing quite a lot into the premium offerings because the profit margins are significantly higher," Bilotka told AFP.

In the most recent quarter, American Airlines said premium revenue increased 18.5% year-over-year, four points better than the main cabin. The boost has been a bright spot in a travel market complicated by the jet fuel spike, American executives said.

"Premium products generate roughly half of the company's ticket revenue on approximately 30% of seats today," American said.

Besides the traditional differentiation between the main cabin and business class, customers may now pay as much as $200 for more legroom or the ability to sit at the front of the plane and disembark first.

United Airlines announced in July that it would offer a new Economy Plus option that allows customers to forgo having a passenger in the dreaded middle seat. United plans to begin this option on some flights at the end of 2026.

In September, JetBlue announced the launch of BlueFirst, a new first-class service on domestic flights. "Customers are increasingly looking for more premium experiences," said JetBlue CEO Joanna Geraghty.

PREMIUM'S STEADY GROWTH

Since 2020, the number of premium seats on US flights has risen 33%, more than double the growth of mainline seats, according to travel news site Skift.

United Airlines more than doubled its premium-seat capacity between 2015 and 2026, the airline told AFP, adding that it plans additional options, like seats with extra elbow room.

In October, British Airways announced that the top level of the two-tier A380 would be composed of premium seats.

Consultancy Cirium estimates that premium seats among the 42 carriers in the three major airline alliances (SkyTeam, Oneworld and Star Alliance) and Middle East carriers now represent 19% of total volume compared with 17.1% in 2019.

Other new options include giving customers choice among meal options prior to boarding and free wifi. There have also been a slew of announcements of new and beautified airport lounges, including by Southwest Airlines, which was once known as a discount carrier. But the increasing tendency of airlines to market to customers who can afford premium amenities could open the door to a discount carrier, although higher fuel costs have added to the challenges facing all airlines.

SEVERAL DEVELOPERS GEAR UP TO LAUNCH PROJECTS IN THE CAPITAL

Delhi Warms Up to High-rise Luxury Housing

Faizan Haidar

New Delhi: Delhi's real estate market is back in focus, with state-run NBCC selling luxury flats in upmarket Chanakyapuri for more than double their reserve price. Homebuyers are also increasingly looking for gated communities within the national capital, without having to move to Noida or Gurugram.

Several developers are preparing to launch projects in Delhi to tap this demand. DLF, TARC, Unity Group, Kreeva and Raheja have already launched premium residential projects in the capital and are planning their next phases.

Historically, Delhi has been predominantly a low-rise, plotted housing market, shaped by builder floors, individual homes and Delhi Development Authority developments. While this has defined the city's character, it has also limited the supply of integrated, amenity-led luxury housing. Over the years, this gap has driven many Delhiites towards markets such as Gurugram and Noida for high-rise communities offering security, club facilities and modern infrastructure.

"However, there has always been a strong underlying preference to remain within Delhi, given its deep cultural, social and emotional connect. What we are now seeing is a natural evolution of the market," said Aakash Ohri, managing director of DLF Home Developers, a unit of DLF. "Select luxury and ultra-luxury high-rise developments by reputed developers are finally coming up within Delhi, addressing a long-standing demand-supply mismatch," he said.

US-based real estate firm Hines, along with Conscient Infrastructure and HDFC Capital, is redeveloping the Birla Cotton Mills site in Kamla Nagar into a high-end mixed-use project. "Delhi is witnessing renewed interest in premium residential developments, driven by homebuyers who increasingly seek spacious homes, well-planned communities and a better quality of life within the city. The growing demand for gated communities reflects a shift in buyer preferences, with greater emphasis on privacy, security, modern amenities and integrated living experiences," said Conscient chief executive Rishi Raj.

POTENTIAL CHANGES

Redevelopment of established land parcels presents an opportunity to create contemporary spaces

Redevelopment of established land parcels, particularly in well-connected locations, presents an opportunity to create contemporary residential spaces while unlocking potential of existing urban areas.

"The response to NBCC's recent auction reinforces the growing demand for premium residential developments within Delhi. For years, buyers seeking the space, privacy and lifestyle of modern gated communities have had to look towards Gurugram or Noida," said Ankush Kaul, chief business officer at real estate developer TARC.

Recently, Poddar Keventer Capital Advisors, an investment management platform backed by the Kolkata-headquartered Saroj Poddar Group (erstwhile Adventz Group) and Keventer Group, launched a ₹400 crore Category-II AIF to invest in projects undertaken by the joint venture in Kolkata and Delhi.

Expansion, Global Orders to Keep M&M on the Growth Path

DIVERSIFICATION GAINS SUV, EV demand & aerospace deals to sustain growth momentum; premiumisation to help tide over near-term shocks

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Mahindra & Mahindra delivered a double-digit revenue and profit growth, driven by robust SUV demand, growing traction in electric vehicles and improving contributions from its financial services, technology and logistics businesses. M&M is banking on capacity expansion, multiple vehicle launches, accelerating EV adoption and the aerospace division to sustain growth momentum.

Shares of M&M gained 10.3% in three trading sessions after declaring quarterly results. While weak monsoons, lower reservoir levels and commodity inflation have led M&M to temper its near-term outlook for the tractor industry, the company expects continued momentum in SUVs, EVs and its diversified portfolio of businesses to underpin earnings growth. The biggest growth trigger remains the SUV division, where demand continues to significantly exceed supply across key models such as Scorpio, Thar, XUV 7XO and the electric vehicle portfolio. M&M expects the segment to deliver mid-to-high-teen growth in FY27, supported by a strong order book, premiumisation and an expanding product portfolio.

Electric vehicles are emerging as the next leg of growth. EV penetration in M&M's SUV portfolio has already surpassed the industry average, driven by strong response to the XEV range and the recent BE 6 Sporteq launch. M&M expects profitability in the EV business to steadily improve through localisation, scale benefits and operating leverage, while analyst see EVs becoming a meaningful contributor to earnings over the next few years.

M&M plans to increase SUV and EV production capacity from around 68,000 units per month currently to 82,000 units by FY27-end, 92,000 units by FY28-end and 132,000 units by FY31. The company's future pipeline also remains robust, with five launches scheduled before June 2027, including a new SUV on the NU_IQ platform, a new EV on INGLO platform, a Lifestyler vehicle, a major product refresh and a new light commercial vehicle.

On the other hand, the company revised its FY27 tractor industry outlook to flattish growth from its earlier expectation of mid-single-digit growth due to weak monsoons, low reservoir levels and drought-like conditions in key states.

Beyond automobiles, businesses such as Mahindra Finance, Tech Mahindra, Last Mile Mobility, logistics and aerospace act as future growth drivers. The aerospace business is gaining scale with increasing global order wins and an ambition to achieve annual order inflows of around $1 billion by FY30, while financial services continue to benefit from improving asset quality.

Although near-term profitability may face the pressure of commodity inflation and a subdued rural environment, brokerages such as ICICI Securities and Prabhudas Lilladher have retained their Buy ratings with target prices implying a 16-18% upside to Sunday's closing price of ₹3,264.7.

In Driver's Seat

Quarterly Standalone Financials of Mahindra & Mahindra (₹ cr)

	Sep 2026	Sep 2025	YoY chg (%)
Income from operations	44,281.9	35,079.8	26.2
EBITDA	6,718.0	6,467.0	3.9
EBITDA margin (%)	15.2	18.4	-327 bps
PAT	5,101.6	4,520.5	12.9

Source: Company data, ETIG

Bps: Basis points (100 bps = One percentage point)

EBITDA: Earnings before interest tax, depreciation and amortisation



Threats

- Commodity inflation
- Subdued rural environment

Brokerages such as **ICICI Securities** and **Prabhudas Lilladher** have retained their **'buy'** ratings

UNDER PRESSURE

Gold, Silver Prices may Sway with US-Iran Tensions

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: Bullion prices are likely to remain under pressure next week as investors track developments in the US-Iran conflict, movements in crude oil prices and inflation data for cues on the outlook for interest rates, analysts said.

The focus will be on inflation prints from China, the US, Germany, Japan and India. Investors will also closely track speeches by Federal Reserve officials and US employment data.

Chinese economic indicators will be important for industrial metals, they added.

Geopolitical developments will remain a key driver after US President Donald Trump confirmed fresh military strikes on Iran, while claiming that Washington had made "a lot of progress" in negotiations with Tehran, adding another layer of uncertainty.

The focus will be on inflation prints from China, US, Germany, Japan and India

WILL REMAIN CLOSED

The domestic commodities market will remain closed during the morning session on Tuesday due to Diwali-Balipratipada.

"Gold and silver's momentum remains down as investors will focus on the inflation data from China, the US, Germany, Japan, India, etc along with some Fed officials' commentary," said Pranav Mer, senior vice president, EBG-Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services.

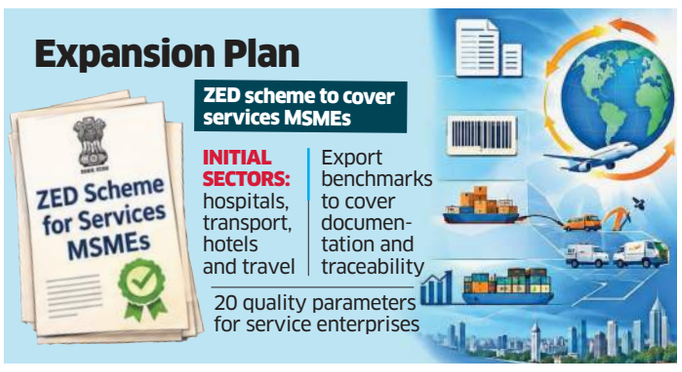
He said investors would also track progress in peace negotiations between the US and Iran to end the war, as well as Russia-Ukraine peace talks.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, gold futures for December delivery gained ₹3,682, or nearly 3%, over the past week to close at ₹1.42 lakh per 10g. Silver futures rose ₹5,655, or 3.15% to settle at ₹1.84 lakh per kg.

No More Zeroes: Govt Lays Out Plan to Better Service Quality

20 parameters to assess service; objective is to make MSMEs competitive, says official

Anoushka Sawhney



New Delhi: The government has prepared a framework to expand its Zero Defect Zero Effect (ZED) certification scheme to the services sector, extending its quality improvement and competitiveness initiative beyond manufacturing to micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs).

The MSME ministry has identified around 20 parameters to assess service enterprises against quality benchmarks. These include timely service delivery, service quality management, facility management, process control, customer management and management of partners, vendors, franchisees and outsourced operations.

The expansion will initially cover sectors such as transport, accommodation, food and beverage services, travel agencies, tour operators and hospitals, according to people aware of the development.

Services sector MSMEs account for 38% of the country's total MSME base, while manufacturing and trading enterprises account for 20% and 42%, respectively.

The ministry has also developed four to five additional parameters for MSME exporters, including export documentation, product traceability and origin verification, to help them meet international quality requirements, said an official.

"The government's objective is to make MSMEs more competitive and prepare them for integration into global value chains," said one official.

The scheme's reach extends beyond certification, with 22 states/UTs having included ZED into their industrial policies and offering additional incentives to ZED-certified MSMEs.

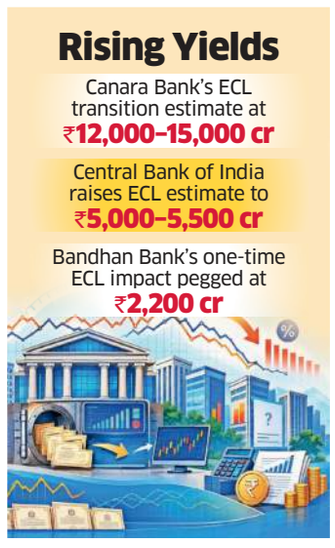
Launched in April 2022, the ZED scheme aims to improve MSME competitiveness by encouraging them to adopt quality standards, reduce wastage, improve productivity and minimise their environmental impact. It is part of the MSME Champions Scheme implemented by the ministry.

The ZED portal said around 10.9 lakh manufacturing MSMEs have registered under the scheme. Of these, 7.7 lakh have received bronze certification, while around 11,000 and 6,000 have received silver and gold certifications, respectively.

Bond Yields Add to Uncertainty as Banks Gear Up for the New Accounting System

Lenders have revised transition estimates as HTM portfolio valuation adds to potential costs

Saloni Shukla



Mumbai: Fluctuations in government bond yields are emerging as a fresh uncertainty for Indian banks preparing to adopt the new accounting framework from April 1, 2027. Several lenders have revised their estimated transition costs, while others are yet to quantify the additional impact of valuing held-to-maturity (HTM) investment portfolios at market prices.

Canara Bank has widened its estimated one-time transition requirement to ₹12,000–15,000 crore, compared with an assessment of about ₹12,000–13,000 crore in July. Central Bank of India has raised its expected credit loss (ECL) provisioning estimate by around ₹500 crore, while Bandhan Bank's latest assessment of ₹2,200 crore is higher than its earlier estimates.

The revised framework requires banks to shift from the existing incurred-loss provisioning system to a forward-looking ECL model, under which lenders must recognise anticipated credit losses before loans become non-performing. Separately, banks will have to revalue their HTM investment portfolios at fair value on March 31, 2027, with the resulting adjustments reflected in reserves.

Canara Bank managing director and CEO Brajesh Kumar Singh said the bank's estimated transition requirement could change depending on prevailing bond yields and its investment holdings.

"HTM will be also mark-to-market. So that will affect us by ₹2,000–3,000 crore," Singh said during the bank's September quarter earnings call.

Central Bank of India has increased its estimated ECL requirement to ₹5,000-5,500 crore from ₹4,500-5,000 crore in July. "Out of those ₹1,525 crore has been already kept as additional provision," managing director and CEO Kalyan Kumar said during the earnings call.

Bandhan Bank has estimated a one-time ECL transition impact of ₹2,200 crore, compared with its initial assessment of ₹1,250 crore made several quarters ago. Managing director and CEO Partha Pratim Sengupta said the ₹2,200 crore calculation was based on the March 2026 loan portfolio and that subsequent improvement in overdue accounts could reduce the eventual requirement.

Indian Bank has estimated an ECL requirement of about ₹3,500 crore, against which it has already created provisions of ₹2,500 crore. However, the bank has not quantified the additional HTM valuation adjustment.

Kotak Mahindra Bank expects a one-time ECL impact of less than 2% of net worth, while Federal Bank estimates its one-time ECL credit-loss impact at 1.5–2% of net worth.

Government bond yields have risen sharply over the past four months, increasing the risk of valuation losses on banks' investment portfolios. The benchmark 10-year G-sec yield climbed to 7.18% at September-end from about 6.75% at June-end, an increase of 43 basis points, before rising further to nearly 7.50% in the last week of October. A basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point. The surge was driven by elevated crude oil prices, rupee weakness, tightening liquidity and expectations of further rate hikes by the Reserve Bank of India, following the 25-basis-point increase in the repo rate in October. However, yields fell sharply to about 7.32% on Monday as declining oil prices triggered a rally in government bonds. Despite the recent decline, yields remain around 57 basis points above late-June levels.

Climate Action Push, Geopolitical Tensions to Weigh on COP31

About 160 issues to be discussed over the next two weeks during UN Climate talks in Türkiye

Urmi Goswami



Antalya: Urgency to accelerate climate action as countries grapple with the economic fallouts of geopolitical tension serves as the backdrop of the 31st round of UN climate talks (COP31) that begins on Monday in the Mediterranean resort town of Antalya in Türkiye.

There are about 160 issues that will be negotiated over the next two weeks. These include the mitigation work programme dealing with emission reduction, the global goal on adaptation, just transition work programme, and a review of the financial mechanism.

The outcomes of the talks will determine the progress made by countries—finance, adaptation and loss and damage, transition to a low carbon pathway that is just, inclusive and fair, and how science informs the efforts to tackle climate change.

Two wars and an unresolved political crisis in the broader neighbourhood continue to exert pressures on national budgets, as governments prioritise defence expenditure, coping with energy crisis and attendant economic impacts. Meanwhile, rising cost of living and protests in many parts of the world by citizens concerned about their future complicates efforts to tackle climate change, at a time when scientists have determined that the world will breach the 1.5 degrees Celsius temperature guardrail.

All this has made COP31 a critical moment in the global collective effort to tackle what many leaders have described as the biggest challenge confronting humanity. Trust, the thread that makes collective action possible, is shrinking. Navigating this complex backdrop to get countries to step up efforts to reduce emissions and adapt to the impacts of climate change, to ensure that developing countries are provided adequate funds, particularly grants and concessional loans, technology and help with capacity building, are Türkiye and Australia.

An arrangement was forged to break the deadlock over which country would host the 2026 round of talks. Türkiye holds the COP31 presidency, with Minister of Environment, Urbanization and Climate Change Murat Kurum serving as COP31 president. Türkiye leads the Action Agenda, including the global call for 35% electrification by 2035. Australia will serve as the president of negotiations, working under the guidance of the COP31 presidency

Australia's Minister for Climate Change and Energy Chris Bowen will lead the formal negotiations.

"COP31 will accelerate practical action and investment to keep global temperatures to safer limits and help build resilience to climate impacts. As lead negotiator, Australia will seek to bring consensus to global climate ambition, including accelerating electrification, unlocking investment, improving access to climate finance and advancing ocean action," said Bowen, COP31 president of negotiations.

Rising cost of living, protests in many parts of the world by citizens complicate efforts to tackle climate change

Türkiye and Australia have announced their intention to have a "cover decision", which is a presidency-led decision negotiated by countries and is essentially a political statement. Recent COP presidencies have used the cover letter to discuss issues that are not included in the official agenda. Bowen said the presidencies did not want to negotiate a lengthy political statement.

What is included in the cover decision will be subject of intense negotiations—with some countries pushing for the inclusion of the electrification goal announced by Türkiye, a definitive statement on the IPCC reports and their role in shaping the stocktaking of the progress made by countries, a roadmap for transitioning away from fossil fuels, and improved financial flows to developing countries.

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personal

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I, Arun Kumar B S, residing at 001, Aditya Residency, Banjara Layout, Horamavu, Bangalore-560043, have changed my name from Aruna Kumar B S / Byrigadde Somanathagowda Aruna Kumar to Arun Kumar B S. All names relate to one and the same person. affidavit dated 4th Nov 2027 at Bangalore

I Sushma W/o Vikrant Hiremath R/o 12, Solapur Road, K C Nagar, VTC: Bijapur, P.O.: Bijapur, District: Vijayapura, Karnataka- 586101, have changed my name to Sushma Hiremath

I, Barasatoo Yadav, F/o, 14834094M– Hav/Spl dvr–Rama Shankar Yadav, R/o, Bishnupur, Jaunpur, UP, changed name to Barsatoo Yadav, for all purpose.

I, Smt Lakshmi Ama, M/o, 6496883H–Hav–Vinod Kumar M, R/o, Thamarakulam, Thamarakulam, Alappuzha, KL, changed name to Lakshmi Pillai, for all purpose.

I, Suresh Patil S/O Basavaraj residing at #04, Heggeri, Old Hubli Dharwad Karnataka, have changed my name to Suresh B Patil Vide affidavit dated 23.09.2026

14872834A SEP/MT Aditya Saxena ASC centre south my mother name service records Poornima changed to Purnima Saxena, for all purpose.

tender & notices

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the general public that I, PRIYA ROY, D/o BENU CHANDRA ROY, R/o No. 202, 4th Floor, 2nd Cross, 2nd Main, Vivek Nagar, Bangalore South, Bengaluru – 560047, was previously known by the name PRIYA ROY and my gender was Female.

I have changed my name from PRIYA ROY to PRIYANSH CHANDRA ROY and my gender from Female to Male.

I shall henceforth be known as PRIYANSH CHANDRA ROY, S/o BENU CHANDRA ROY, R/o No. 202, 4th Floor, 2nd Cross, 2nd Main, Vivek Nagar, Bangalore South, Bengaluru – 560047, for all purposes and in all official records.

PRIYA ROY

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is for general information that I was previously known as ARJUN UPADHYAY S/o KAMALA KANT UPADHYAY R/O 13/1, S. K. Nagar, Rishra, Hooghly, Pravashnagar, West Bengal, 712249, and after being diagnosed with Gender Dysphoria under the supervision of a registered medical practitioner in Bengaluru , have changed my gender to female. I henceforth be known as VAANI UPADHYAY , D/o KAMALA KANT UPADHYAY R/O 13/1, S. K. Nagar, Rishra, Hooghly, Pravashnagar, West Bengal, 712249. It is certified that I have complied with other legal requirements in the connection.

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'Int'l Insurance Cover May Help Boost Medical Tourism'

PTI

Bangkok: Once insurance companies start covering treatment expenses for foreign patients coming to India, medical tourism numbers could shoot up exponentially, a top Apollo Hospitals official has said.

"Global insurance companies enabling international usage automatically.. and not just enabling... (but) encouraging will help save (patients) a lot of money," Apollo Hospitals joint managing director Sangita Reddy said.

Speaking to PTI on the sidelines of the Garmin Health Summit in Bangkok, Reddy said, "We have requested the government to lead us on a delegation to work with the insurance companies. If they start covering... then you will see a large segment of the Western world coming here".

India has emerged as one of the most significant destinations in the global landscape

"We have a significant number of NRIs coming in. It is a win-win for all sides," she said. According to official figures, the global medical travel market was valued at around $115.6 billion in 2022 and is projected to reach around $286.1 billion by 2030.

India has emerged as one of the most significant destinations in this evolving global landscape.

Industry estimates place the medical tourism market around $8.7 billion in 2025.

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Unpopular opinion: if AI didn't make you 10x better, the problem was never the AI

Tech Buzz

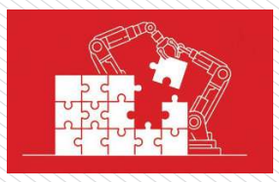
OpenAI Bags $11 billion at $1.25T Value



WASHINGTON: OpenAI has secured roughly $11 billion in fresh funding, the first tranche of a larger round that values the company at $1.25 trillion, according to people familiar with the matter. The funding was wired to the company as of Friday, said the people, who spoke on condition of anonymity. The remainder of the round, which could increase to as much as $20 billion in total, is expected to be completed in the coming weeks, one person said. The AI developer has been in talks for more than a month to raise a large funding round after delaying its plans for an initial public offering. OpenAI initially set out to raise $30 billion or more at a $1.4 trillion valuation, Bloomberg News has reported, before scaling back its plans amid a public market rout for the AI sector. – **Bloomberg**

6 GW
Projected data centre capacity in India by 2029, up from 1.6 GW in mid-2026 – JLL Report

SoftBank, ABB Eye Carve-Out to Salvage Deal



TOKYO: Japan's SoftBank and Swiss engineering group ABB are looking at carving out the Chinese element of a $5.4 billion robotics deal which was blocked earlier this week by Beijing, Bloomberg News reported. SoftBank did not respond to requests for comment and ABB declined to comment on the report which said that a carve-out would mean setting up a separate entity for the China business with different ownership. This is the second deal blocked by China this year after Meta was ordered in April to unwind its more than $2 billion acquisition of AI startup Manus, as Beijing tightens scrutiny of foreign investment involving frontier technologies. ABB is considering other options including finding another buyer, the report said, adding that the business could potentially be valued at $3 billion. – **Reuters**

Jargon Buster

Context Rot
The degradation of an AI agent's performance or accuracy as its conversation/context window fills up with clutter or outdated information

Digi Lenders Clock 50% Revenue Growth as Credit Demand Surges

Digital lenders outpace banks on a youth credit wave, but rising indebtedness sparks caution

Ayanti Bera & Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: Listed new-age fintech companies reported 40-50% growth in lending and financial services revenue in the September quarter, driven by strong loan disbursements and rising demand for unsecured credit from younger borrowers, as India's broader retail lending market continued to expand.

Digital lender Kissht's revenue from operations rose 44.7% year-on-year to ₹732 crore, while Moneyview reported 41% growth to ₹1,120 crore. MobiKwik's financial services revenue increased 41.8% to ₹87 crore, while Paytm's financial services distribution revenue grew 49.3% to ₹912 crore.

The growth reflects a broader expansion in household and small-business credit, a key indicator of domestic consumption and economic activity. According to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), retail lending by non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) grew 21.9% year-on-year in September, compared with 16.8% a year earlier. Banks' personal loan portfolios expanded 17.3% during the same period, against 11.5% last year.

Larger lenders, which typically operate across a wider range of secured lending products, are also benefiting from sustained demand. Bajaj Finserv, reported a 26% increase in assets under management (AUM) to ₹5.85 lakh crore, booking 13.45 million new loans during the quarter, up 11%.

Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company's AUM grew 25% to ₹2.68 lakh crore, while quarterly disbursements jumped 47% to ₹35,872 crore.

Jinay Gala, director at India Ratings & Research, said the relatively smaller base of digital lenders and their ability to reach borrowers underserved by traditional financial institutions were driving faster growth.

"Banks have been slow on personal loans and unsecured lending, allowing fintechs to serve more self-employed and Gen Z borrowers," he said.



Disbursements surge as fintechs expand loan books and tap growing demand for unsecured credit

Company	Q2 Revenue (in ₹ cr)	YoY Growth in revenue (in %)	Lending scale snapshot
Kissht	732	44.7	Q2 disbursals ₹4,612 crore; AUM ₹9,317 cr
Moneyview	1,120	41	Q2 disbursals ₹7,701 cr; AUM ₹23,892 cr
MobiKwik	87	41.8	Q2 disbursals ₹1,083 crore
Paytm*	912	49.3	Q2 financial services distribution business

ET Insight

By successfully capturing the Gen Z wallet, digital platforms have positioned themselves as the primary gatekeepers of future retail consumption

SMALLER BASE, BIGGER GAINS

The acceleration is visible in the pace of loan disbursements. Moneyview facilitated loans worth ₹7,701 crore during the quarter, up 41.3% year-on-year, while Kissht's disbursements rose 56% to ₹4,612 crore. MobiKwik reported a 34% increase to ₹1,083 crore.

The figures include loans originated through lending partners as well as their own NBFC subsidiaries.

Moneyview, which primarily serves consumers outside India's largest cities, said about 75% of its lending capital comes from partner institutions, allowing it to expand without proportionately increasing its own balance sheet.

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Big IT Chasing the Tail as Mid-market Offers Faster Growth

IT majors deploying flexible deal models to capture the mid-market wallet share



Growth Push
($1m+ Category| MAR-SEPT)

Infosys added the most clients (30), taking its total to **1,048** clients

TCS added 15, reaching **1,412** clients

Persistent added **19** clients

Mphasis and Wipro added **12** and **11,** respectively

LTM was the only exception, losing **13** clients in the quarter

HCLTech and Tech Mahindra saw modest client additions in quarter

Shristi Achar

Bengaluru: India's top nine IT services companies are seeing faster growth in their smaller client accounts than in their large enterprise relationships.

The number of customers generating $1-10 million in annual revenue increased at most of these companies in the first half of fiscal 2027 from a year earlier, even as that of their big clients remained largely flat or grew at a slower pace.

Between March and September, Infosys added 30 clients in the $1 million-plus category, taking the total to 1,048. At Tata Consultancy Services, the number increased by 15 to 1,412, while Persistent (19), Mphasis (12) and Wipro (11) also added such clients in the first six months.

HCLTech and Tech Mahindra recorded smaller net additions. Coforge reported a sharp increase, though its client buckets are not directly comparable with the cumulative thresholds disclosed by several peers. LTM was an exception, with its count declining by 13.

At the higher end, the number of $100 million-plus clients was largely unchanged across companies that disclose the category. The movement was limited in the $50 million-plus segment, while additions in $10 million-plus deals were more modest than those in the $1 million-plus category.

The trend points to a growing contribution to revenue from mid-size accounts, as large IT services providers look beyond their biggest customers for incremental growth.

"Top-client dependence is falling for most top companies, the second rank of accounts are growing, and the tail is shrinking…all three things are happening at the same time," said Biswajeet Mahapatra, principal analyst at Forrester.

The opportunity in these accounts is not limited to winning new business. "The headroom to grow in mid-sized accounts is significant, because you are only taking a portion of the wallet share. Your ability to increase the wallet share is higher in the mid-market accounts," Mahapatra said. Decision-making also happens relatively faster in such contracts.

Number of $100 m-plus clients was largely unchanged across companies

This is prompting large providers to build offerings for the mid-market, a segment where smaller and more focused vendors have traditionally had an advantage. Flexible commercial models and the ability to take on smaller projects can help providers establish relationships and expand them over time, especially as clients are becoming more cautious about committing to large, long-term programmes and increasingly want to test outcomes before extending engagements.

"Indian IT companies are growing the number of mid-sized and large accounts, and their dependence on a few top clients is easing at most companies. Clients are consolidating vendors, which rewards firms that are already embedded in an account and can take on more scope," said Praveen Bhadada, chief executive of tech consultancy Neovay Global.

118 PROJECTS APPROVED UNDER ₹40KCR SCHEME

Forged at Home Inside ₹77kcr Plan Rewiring India's Tech DNA Forever

Thirteen months after launching the flagship Electronic Component Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS), the Centre has greenlit 118 investment applications across 16 states to build a localised tech supply chain. The initiative is already delivering results, with 38 facilities in active production plugging domestic gaps and 16 units progressing through machinery setup. Small and medium enterprises drive half of these ventures. Spanning six tranches, ECMS approvals strategically target critical upstream gaps to slash import dependence on foundational items, including flexible and multi-layer printed circuit boards, copper-clad laminates, and rare-earth permanent magnets made from neodymium and dysprosium, writes ET's **Subhayan Chakraborty**

INDIA'S COMPONENT PLAN

ECMS INITIAL OUTLAY ₹22,919 crore in April 2025

EXPANDED TO ₹40,000 crore in FY27 budget

NATIONAL TARGET BY 2030

$500b (₹47.75 lakh crore) domestic electronics manufacturing,
$150b (₹14.33 lakh cr) electronics exports, 35-40% value addition

ET GRAPHICS

PROGRESS ON KEY TARGETS

CUMULATIVE INVESTMENTS
Targeted 59,350cr
Committed 77,051cr

CUMULATIVE PROJECTED PRODUCTION
Targeted 4,56,500cr
Committed 5,73,146cr

JOB CREATION
Targeted 91,600 direct jobs
Committed 81,755 direct + 2.5 lakh indirect jobs

SECTORAL SPREAD 34 PRODUCT CATEGORIES

PCBs 24 units	Capacitors 5 units	Antennas & heat sinks 4 units
Capital goods 12 units	Display modules 5 units	Metallised films 4 units
Connectors 9 units	Enclosures 5 units	Anode material 3 units
Relays 7 units	Laminates 4 units	Li-ion cell 2 units
Camera modules 6 units	Resistors & transducers 4 units	Rare-earth magnets 2 units
Optical transceivers 6 units		Others 16 units

FACILITY FOOTPRINT
CURRENT & UPCOMING UNITS IN 16 STATES

Tamil Nadu 23 units
Karnataka 20 units
Maharashtra 17 units
Uttar Pradesh 13 units
Haryana 9 units
Andhra Pradesh 8 units
Kerala 6 units
Gujarat 5 units
Madhya Pradesh 4 units
Rajasthan 2 units

Telangana, Goa, Jammu & Kashmir, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand at least 1 unit each

Source: Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), officials

Google Exec Harrison Exits SpaceX Board

NEW YORK: SpaceX disclosed that Google executive Donald Harrison has resigned from the rockets-to-AI company's board after more than a decade. Harrison notified SpaceX of his resignation on November 4, and it took effect immediately. The Elon Musk-led company said Harrison's decision to resign was not due to any disagreement with the company on matters relating to its operations, policies or practices. Harrison, a longtime executive at Google, is currently president of Global Partnerships and Corporate Development. Google parent Alphabet is the largest single institutional holder of SpaceX, as per the LSEG data. – **Reuters**

SpaceX Embrace of Compute Deals Eases its Reliance on US Contracts

Musk finds a bigger payday leasing supercomputers to Silicon Valley

Bloomberg

New York: SpaceX's reliance on US government-funded contracts will continue to shrink, Elon Musk said, signaling a shift in focus away from what was previously his rocket-launch company's most important partnership.

Payments from the government agencies that SpaceX works with will make up less than 10% of the company's revenue this quarter, Musk said in response to a user on his X social media platform. That compares with 16.6% in the most recent quarter.

It continues a steady downward financial trend for SpaceX's contracts with NASA and the Department of Defense, which previously used to be the company's most lucrative partnerships. It also underscores SpaceX's reliance on the handful of customers leasing its data centre computing power — an AI neocloud business strategy Wall Street has recently turned against.

SpaceX has become the backbone of the US space program and has benefitted from numerous contracts to launch astronauts and important national security satellites for NASA and the Pentagon. Rival contractors have also complained the Defense Department is tailoring contracts so narrowly that only SpaceX can win.



Musk previously predicted that NASA, historically SpaceX's biggest customer, would only make up 5% of the company's revenue this year. SpaceX still holds a key contract with NASA to send humans to the moon on its Starship rocket as early as 2028.

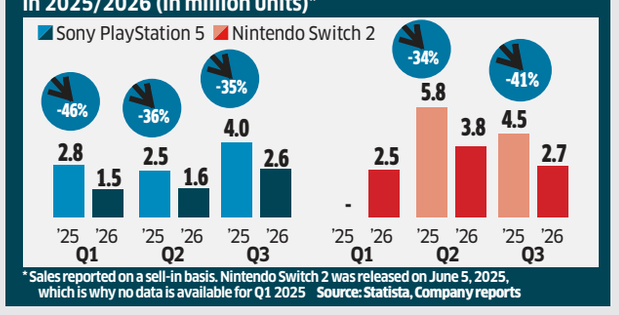
The chief executive officer offered bullish growth forecasts later on Friday, telling a Baron investment conference that SpaceX's fourth-quarter revenue would jump "something like" 70% from the prior period.

Musk also reaffirmed SpaceX was on track to close out the year with $100 billion in annualised revenue, with the same measure soaring above $500 billion by the end of 2027.

Tech Trotter — Meanwhile in tech...

Video Game Console Sales Plunge as Prices Skyrocket

Sales of Sony's and Nintendo's flagship video game consoles in 2025/2026 (in million units)*



*Sales reported on a sell-in basis. Nintendo Switch 2 was released on June 5, 2025, which is why no data is available for Q1 2025 **Source:** Statista, Company reports

Samsung Set to be 1st SKorean Co with Massive $147b Cash Assets

Seoul: Helped by the artificial intelligence-led chip supercycle, Samsung Electronics is poised to become the first South Korean company with cash assets of over 200 trillion won ($146.6 billion), industry data showed on Sunday. Cash and cash equivalents at the chip giant are estimated to have reached 214.8 trillion won as of the third quarter, up 24.8 trillion won from 190 trillion won recorded three months earlier, according to the data. The amount is also nearly double from the 108.5 trillion won recorded at the end of the third quarter of 2025, reports Yonhap news agency. — **Agencies**

Eco-warriors Byte the Bullet on High-Carbon AI Data Centres

Green groups deploy AI for real-time climate solutions while implementing edge computing and query restrictions to shrink tech's footprint

Reuters

Washington: Environmental groups worldwide are using artificial intelligence to analyse climate data, track forest fires and count endangered wildlife—embracing a technology they also warn is driving a surge in electricity demand, water use and greenhouse-gas emissions.

The contradiction is forcing these organisations to justify their AI use in carrying out missions to combat climate change or protect natural resources. "We recognise that AI can come with environmental costs, and we need to be thoughtful about how we use it," said Ali Swanson, AI lead at the US nonprofit Conservation International. "But at a time when the climate and biodiversity crises are becoming more urgent, AI can help us move faster and make better use of the information we're collecting." The group recently started using AI to assess hotspots detected by satellites and send real-time alerts to community forest patrols about potential wildfires in remote and environmentally sensitive parts of Cambodia.

Reuters interviewed 15 major environmental, conservation and development organisations about their AI use. All said they used the technology in some form and expressed concern about the environmental impact of the data centers powering it. The centers, filled with servers, can require vast amounts of electricity, along with water for cooling.



It's a global dilemma for individuals, governments and industries balancing AI's benefits with its enormous risks. The tradeoffs likely will grab attention at the UN's COP31 climate conference this month, when host Turkey will call on governments, businesses and other institutions to sign a pledge outlining principles to ensure AI is developed and deployed sustainably.

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres wants major AI companies to publicly disclose their systems' environmental impacts.

WEIGHING AI'S ECO-COST

Many green organisations believe AI's benefits currently outweigh its costs

Researchers at the United Nations University Institute for Water, Environment and Health estimate the global data-centre footprint could more than double by 2030, reaching a size about twice that of Jakarta, the Indonesian megalopolis.

India's Huge ChatGPT Appetite & AI Health

Price-sensitive (read: stingy) market poses a test

India has become the largest market for ChatGPT. This follows a familiar script of technology adoption that makes it a global node for AI dispersal. Few markets compare with India's sheer population of digitally connected users. Data is vital to the development of AI models. Critically, though, the country also has one of the world's largest pools of trained manpower that can deliver secondary innovation with emerging technology. This gives India a rare optimism despite AI's disruptive potential. Low levels of AI infra development in India have muted opposition to the mounting resource needs of data centres. Of course, the most compelling reason for the rapid rise of AI use in India is that it is free for a vast majority.

Consumer AI works on a freemium model where basic versions are made free and advanced capabilities require a paid subscription. AI hyperscalers use this to build user bases. Investments in AI infrastructure subsidise free user accounts and the interaction data helps improve underlying models. But the productivity gains from AI are expected to emerge from the paid tier of services. Only a small percentage of users pays for advanced queries, and this segment is now exposed to sticker shock. Companies are realising higher model consumption does not always translate into a boost in employee productivity or cost savings. Operational expenses of AI coding have, in some instances, exceeded human coding.



Indian AI usage is a 'free rider' problem. People are benefiting from AI services without contributing to their cost. This changes when sovereign AI infra begins to take shape. The energy and computing costs will have to be recovered from consumers. That is a tricky proposition in India's price-sensitive market. A large part of the country's digital infra is built with public money, and the question of user fees remains a sticking point well after universal adoption of digital payments. AI has yet to conclusively establish its benefits for more price-sensitive (read: parsimonious) Indian users to open their wallets.

Time to COP-erate With Others, India?

At a time when climate action seems to be at a crossroads, COP31 gets underway in Antalya, Türkiye, today. Necessitated by compromise, it will be a double act — Türkiye is designated COP31 president and Australia is president of negotiations. The duo has made implementation of climate commitments and targets the central theme of the talks. This unusual partnership will see a great deal of interaction between two parts of the annual talks — the climate action agenda, which is voluntary and includes all stakeholders, and negotiations by governments. For India, COP31 is an opportunity to showcase its efforts to transition to a low-carbon economy and to build a coalition that makes it possible for all countries, especially developing countries, to grow without endangering the planet.



Indications are that India will stick to its traditional lines — on climate finance, insisting that developed countries need to pay up by allocating public money as grants and concessional loans. New Delhi has said that it will not agree to any roadmap to transition away from fossil fuels or accept any new targets, such as one for electrification, as its priority is development and ensuring access for all.

New Delhi must try to find common ground with other developing countries. Doing so will require India to think and act out of the box. India should champion transition roadmaps prepared by Brazil. It must advocate for improved financial flows to developing countries, not just more money. Considering the geopolitical turmoil and economic pressures, India must help craft a pathway that allows for collaborative action. This can be its moment to shape the climate conversation. But to do so, it must get others on board to move beyond just noble intentions.



THINK ABOUT IT

Time we mythologised our places by putting them in songs

'Route NH44', 'Sweet Home Allahabad'...

America has built much of its mythology not merely on geography but on geography set to music. 'Route 66' is a road that Bobby Troup turned into an adventure. Chuck Berry transformed Memphis, Tennessee, into a rock-'n'-roll destination. John Denver made West Virginia into an emotional homeland for people who couldn't locate it on a map. The Eagles made California a hotel from which nobody could check out. And Frank Sinatra's New York remains the world's most successful municipal ad campaign that even Mamdani can't top.

Blues, country, rock and pop have accomplished what tourism departments haven't: turning places into states of mind. India's been modest, so far, on this front. 'Bombay se aaya mera dost', 'Aati kya Khandala', 'Bareli ke bazaar me/ Jhumka gira re', are a handful. Where's our 'Sweet Home Allahabad'? 'Kalkatta Dreaming'? 'Dilli Calling' could be a punk rock anthem. 'Gurgaon on My Mind' can become a jazz standard. 'Born in the BKC' can be an iconic power song whose irony most people won't get. India has enough towns, heartbreaks and questionable highways to sustain several musical catalogues. What it needs is fewer songs merely filmed in exotic locations like Dubai and the Mediterranean, and more songs that make ordinary places exotic and legendary. Geography becomes mythology when somebody bypasses GPS and gives it a mic.

SWAMISPEAK RE can help India meet climate goals without waiting for deals or US generosity

Enough of COP Jamborees



Swaminathan S Anklesaria Aiyar

Donald Trump rejects climate science, but cannot repeal the economics of sunshine. As countries assemble for COP31 that starts in Antalya, Türkiye, today, the most encouraging development is that green electricity makes commercial sense without requiring governments to agree on who should pay.

Climate conferences have traditionally resembled negotiations over a hospital bill, with rich countries disputing their liabilities and poor countries demanding assistance. Those arguments still have some force for adaptation and climate damage. But electricity generation increasingly offers a different proposition: go for RE because it is cheaper.



For India, electricity can now go green entirely on commercial grounds, without requiring US generosity

Energy think-tank Ember supplies striking evidence. Its April report concludes that solar energy plus storage batteries can meet 90% of India's future electricity demand at ₹5.06 a unit. Bids at recent auctions for coal-based thermal power ranged from ₹5 to ₹6.30. Sunshine now challenges coal after sunset, too.

Ember assumes unrestricted transmission. Its figure excludes full delivery costs and supply of the remaining 10%. Monsoon shortfalls will require additional other sources. Yet, the competitive frontier has shifted decisively to renewables, even if solar has not become the cheapest answer everywhere, every hour.

This changes the politics of COP31. RE, in India and all but some least developed countries, can attract market finance without grants or operating subsidies. US withdrawal from climate funding may hurt adaptation finance. But, for India, electricity can now go green entirely on commercial grounds, without requiring US generosity.

International Renewable Energy Agency (Irena) estimates that installed solar costs have fallen 87% since 2010, and battery storage costs 93%. Moreover, costs keep falling year after year. This needs no major breakthroughs in technology, just marginal annual improvements. Progress will fluctuate. Interest rates, trade barriers and material prices can temporarily overwhelm engineering gains. But for long-term planning, RE is now the cheapest source, regardless of one's views on climate change.

Today's solar technology is dominated by monocrystalline silicon. Perovskites offer an exciting advance. Their most plausible near-term role is as a layer above silicon in tandem cells, capturing wavelengths that silicon uses less efficiently. This will build upon established tech and, therefore, become commercial much faster than totally new technologies.

Oxford PV has already shipped commercial tandem panels. Its targets envisage 27% module efficiency in 2027 and 30% in 2030, although durability and mass production remain challenges. Sodium-ion batteries offer an alternative to lithium-iron phosphate batteries for storage, but have yet to prove themselves cheaper. Neither breakthrough is necessary for immediate progress.

India should concentrate on 4 priorities:

❶ Electrify transport Do this especially for 2- and 3-wheelers, buses, and suitable commercial fleets. Cheap electricity can replace imported petroleum, improve urban air and reduce exposure to oil shocks. Charging should follow electricity availability, encouraging daytime consumption wherever vehicles and operating schedules permit.



The annual COPs are not needed. Gone are the days of moral lecturing on the need for trillions of dollars in concessional finance to save the planet

❷ Agrivoltaics panels These can be developed on sufficiently high stilts for cultivation below. While generating solar power, this arrangement provides enough sunshine to grow some vegetable and fodder crops, though not cereals. Shade can help conserve moisture. But elevated structures cost more. We need to establish through demonstration projects which crops can be grown profitably under solar panels in which agroclimatic conditions.

❸ Invest in transmission and grid stability India is currently building solar farms faster than wires needed to carry power to distant users. In Rajasthan especially, so much solar power is produced that the transmission system cannot cope. Excess production means the market price of solar power falls to zero in daytime for want of transmission. Look at the absurdity: sunshine arrives free, panels have been paid for, yet generation must be switched off.

Storage batteries help shift afternoon surpluses into evening demand. They cannot replace every missing transmission corridor. India also needs faster land clearances for lines, better forecasting, flexible demand, modern inverters, and ancillary services that maintain voltage and frequency.

❹ Reliable payments by discoms Cheap technology cannot finance unpaid bills. Too many state-owned distribution companies still suffer massive losses because politicians want to give free power to favoured lobbies (farmers, low-income urban users), and simply stop paying generators for electricity. This, rather than carbon emissions, is the most unsustainable part of the current electricity system.

What about rising interest rates? Solar requires most expenditure upfront, making finance unusually important. Ember assumes a 7% discount rate over 20 yrs. As a simplified illustration, raising that rate to 10% increases the annual capital-recovery charge by a stiff 24%. But coal-based and nuclear power will also face higher financing costs. So, improving solar tech should let RE maintain its commercial edge.

The annual jamboree of COPs is not needed. Gone are the days of moral lecturing on the need for trillions of dollars in concessional finance to save the planet. India should transition to zero net carbon at its own pace, using its own ability to attract global finance.

Most important, it must tackle the political hurdle of requiring customers to pay for the power they consume. That does not require finance from Trump, or resolutions from COP jamborees.

Tariff Threat & AI Invest Still Alive



Pulkit Kapoor

Before the US midterms, the central question for India was not who would win Congress, but whether the election would alter the forces shaping global capital, trade and energy markets. After the results, the question has become whether those forces have changed.

Markets appear to be interpreting the outcome as a setback for AI-linked investment, tariffs and executive unilateralism. It isn't. Investors may be overestimating implications of the 'Blue Wave' on geopolitics. The election does little to alter the strategic tensions that define the current equilibrium in West Asia.

Whether the region experiences renewed escalation will depend more on military and diplomatic calculations than congressional arithmetic. For India, consequences would be felt through higher oil prices, imported inflation and pressure on BoP. The more relevant questions for India, therefore, concern trade and capital flows.

A Democrat-loaded Congress may weaken the executive's negotiating position at the margin, giving India additional room in trade negotiations. The experience of February is instructive. Once US Supreme Court invalidated tariffs imposed under IEEPA, India's bargaining position improved. Balance of negotiating leverage shifted even though the underlying disagreements remained unchanged.

The same distinction applies today. Congress may increase oversight of executive action and challenge the broad use of tariffs against allies and trading partners. That may strengthen India's hand in ongoing negotiations. But it would be a mistake to assume that the tariff threat has disappeared.

Principal authorities used to impose tariffs, including Sections 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962 and Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974, remain within the executive's reach. Beyond those, Congress has granted executive authority that could be used to impose punitive tariffs of up to 100% on countries purchasing Russian crude oil. Whether that authority is deployed will depend on the direction of Washington's strategic priorities.

The election outcome opens two contradictory paths. If congressional Democrats prioritise repairing ties with allies and scrutinising unilateral trade actions, the practical impact on India may be limited. If, however, they prioritise increasing pressure on Russia and enforcing sanctions compliance, tariff risks for India could increase.



India shouldn't abhor a vacuum

History offers another reason for caution. The assumption that one party is inherently less protectionist than the other has proved unreliable. The Biden administration not only retained many of Trump 1.0 tariffs but expanded industrial policy measures, including 100% tariffs on Chinese EVs. Tariffs have increasingly become a bipartisan feature of US industrial and trade policy.

Some investors appear tempted to interpret the result as a voter backlash against AI. Evidence suggests something more nuanced. In several constituencies, voters expressed concerns about rising electricity bills, pressure on local infra, water consumption and potential disruption to jobs.

Yet, AI remains one of the few strategic priorities that enjoys support across the US political spectrum. Competition with China, semiconductor leadership and belief that AI will underpin future economic growth, have created a durable bipartisan consensus in favour of continued investment. Policymakers now confront a different set of incentives from voters. The more likely outcome is adaptation rather than retrenchment.

So, the more important battleground may shift away from Washington and toward the states. Questions about who pays for grid expansion, transmission upgrades, water usage and power generation are increasingly being contested at the sub-national level. But even there, the outcome is more likely to involve a renegotiation of costs than abandonment of projects. That distinction matters for India.

Some investors may hope that regulatory friction in the US will free up capital for EMs. There's little evidence to support that assumption. If data centre projects slow in one state, capital can shift to transmission networks, semiconductor manufacturing, power infrastructure or other parts of the AI value chain. Competition for capital is, therefore, likely to remain predominantly within the US, rather than shift meaningfully towards EMs, India included.

For India, the challenge is not whether the US AI boom slows, but whether it can remain sufficiently attractive to global investors. The Blue Wave may alter political narratives but it does little to change that underlying reality.

The writer is senior vice-president, Business & Economic Research, Axis Bank

Healthcare Needs Team Effort

Mayank Bathwal & Dilip Jose

Healthcare's purpose is to help people lead healthier lives and, when they need treatment, to ensure they receive appropriate care at the right time and in the right setting.

This depends on patients, providers and payers working as one connected system. Their roles are distinct, but their interests converge on a common objective: better outcomes for patients through care that is high-quality, accessible and financially sustainable.

Historically, the relationship between hospitals and insurers has been transactional, with one delivering care and the other paying for it. Given the growing complexity of healthcare and rising patient expectations, this model is no longer adequate. The opportunity before us is to evolve the payer-provider relationship into a genuine partnership.

Payers and providers share an interest in clinical outcomes. Hospitals are committed to delivering evidence-based care that achieves the best possible results, and insurers are committed to ensuring access to care while providing financial protection. When the two work together, the conversation can move beyond cost to the patient's health outcome.

Such collaboration supports early detection, appropriate treatment, better management of chronic conditions and stronger post-discharge care. It also helps reduce avoidable complications, unnecessary procedures and readmissions. Patients receive well-timed care, providers can deliver better care, insurers serve a healthier population, and healthcare expenditure becomes more sustainable over the long term.

Appropriate care is central to any well-functioning healthcare system. The objective should be to ensure that each patient receives the care that clinical evidence supports, when they need it, rather than to maximise treatment or simply to minimise cost.

Greater sharing of clinical guidelines and evidence-based treatment pathways will strengthen confidence between providers and insurers. In due course, this should shift discussions from individual approvals and claims towards agreed standards of care and outcomes. Such an approach respects clinical judgement while offering patients and payers greater predictability.



At the heart of the matter

Trust is essential in healthcare and it rests on transparency. Patients should understand the treatment they are receiving, the reason for it, its cost and the extent of their insurance coverage. Any lack of clarity adds to anxiety of patients and families who are under considerable stress.

Providers and insurers can address this together. Digital integration between hospitals and insurers can simplify pre-authorisations, documentation and claims, reducing the administrative burden for all parties. The principle should be clear: patients should not have to act as intermediaries between their hospital and their insurer. Advances in technology and process integration now make it possible for both to coordinate in the background, allowing patients to concentrate on their recovery.

Healthcare is increasingly extending beyond the hospital. Patients require support across prevention, screening, diagnosis, inpatient treatment, rehabilitation, home care, medication, remote monitoring and the long-term management of chronic conditions.

Collaboration between payers and providers is critical here. Together, they can develop programmes that encourage healthier lifestyles and earlier detection of disease, so that insurance plays a role well before hospitalisation.

Preventive health checks, disease management programmes, teleconsultations, home care, rehabilitation and remote monitoring can increasingly form part of an integrated continuum of care. For chronic conditions such as diabetes, heart disease and cancer, success is determined by how effectively a patient's health is managed over months and years, rather than by a single hospital stay.

Providers have visibility into the clinical journey, while payers have insight into long-term health patterns and claims. When these datasets are combined responsibly, the industry's focus can move from the volume of procedures to clinical outcomes, early intervention and long-term health.

At the same time, as healthcare becomes more digital, it must remain human. Hospitals must provide compassionate care, and insurers must ensure that approvals are simple and predictable, and that coverage is easy to understand.

The future of healthcare will require a fundamental shift from treating individual episodes of illness to managing health over a person's lifetime. No single stakeholder can achieve this.

The next phase of healthcare should be defined by collaboration around the patient rather than negotiation between payer and provider. Progress will be evident when providers and payers share information more effectively, coordinate around evidence-based care, improve transparency, simplify the patient journey, and measure success by health outcomes rather than transactions.

Ultimately, healthcare needs partnerships that ensure every patient receives appropriate care, achieves better outcomes and can access that care with confidence.

Bathwal is CEO, Aditya Birla Health Insurance. Jose is MD-CEO, Manipal Hospitals

THE SPEAKING TREE

Brightest Within

DADA J P VASWANI

In every heart, there is a point of light shining. It is the light divine. You can see it only when you turn within. Rishis of ancient India have described the human heart as a cave; deep inside is this light that shines bright. It is a point of light within. This light is beautiful to behold.

Man is ever in search of inner peace. He is in search of this light. He climbs mountains, he trudges over deserts, he travels to the poles to catch a glimpse of Northern or Southern lights; but all that is in vain. What he needs to do is turn within. Enter the cave, the dark deep cave of your heart, and behold! The bright point of light, magical, eternal and overwhelming, fills you with its radiance.

You may commit many sins; you may live a life that is evil and dehumanising. All that is outside the range of light. The dark evil doings are on the surface of life. All this evil can never, ever extinguish this light, for it is eternal.

The day this light pierces the darkness of the heart and glows with its unique inner radiance, you will receive answers to your many questions. Once you have its vision, you will know your true identity. You will know the reason why you are here. You will know the purpose of your life. You will clearly see the goal and the path you must walk to attain it.



MELODY FOR MONDAY

Nazrana Bheja Kisi Ne Pyar Ka

Rajesh Roshan/ Kishore Kumar

There are love songs that plead, others that pine, and still others that behave as if romance were a terminal illness. Then there's Rajesh Roshan's 'Nazrana Bheja Kisi Ne Pyar Ka' from the 1978 Dev Anand film, Des Pardes. Kishore Kumar here sounds like a man who has just discovered that being in love is not merely wonderful but ridiculously happy-making.

The song's greatness lies in the sheer, unembarrassed happiness of his singing. Kishore



doesn't so much deliver the melody as unwrap it, with that unmistakable elasticity of voice, mischievous warmth, and effortless ability to make even the simplest phrase sound like a private celebration.

Amit Khanna's delightful lyrics — 'Nazrana bheja kisi ne pyar ka/ Hai diwana jo bas tere didaar ka (Someone has sent a gift of love/ he's a fool crazy just for a glimpse of you' — understand something that more solemn romantic poets frequently miss: love need not arrive burdened with metaphysical anguish. It can be a gift, a surprise, an occasion for uncomplicated delight.

What makes the song irresistible is its complete absence of cynicism. Kishore sings without justification or restraint.

Chat Room

It's a Package, Warts and All

Apropos 'Stakeholders' Views Differ on LTCG Tax, STT' by Deepshikha Sikarwar and Nishanth Vasudevan (Nov 6), it's unusual to hear from foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) that they would want a tax break on long-term capital gains (LTCG) for them to invest in Indian markets. Exchange rates and taxes are part of market risks, which they are accustomed to in all foreign markets they invest in. FPIs played a valuable role in India's smaller capital markets in the earlier decades, providing international investors with much-needed exposure to the Indian growth story. FPIs continue to play a useful role in the market; however, granting them tax concessions would create an uneven playing field among market participants. The country should actually be mindful of foreign direct investments (FDI), rather than FPIs.

P Sreekumar
Mumbai

ET Markets: Beating Volatility

India Inc's Credit Profile Remains Healthy

SMART INVESTING ▸▸ 8



HOPE SPARKLES Sentiment has been improving though with $3.6 billion of foreign purchases this month; Nifty's over 8% gain last week was its biggest weekly rise since February 2021

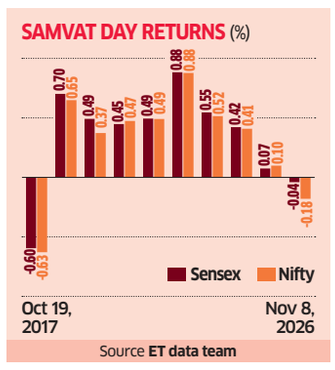
Sensex & Nifty Fall in Muhurat Trade for First Time Since 2017

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equities closed marginally lower in Muhurat trading that marked the beginning of Samvat 2083, with the Sensex and Nifty recording their first declines on the special Diwali session since 2017. The Sensex ended at 80,999.40, down 28.62 points, or 0.04%, while the Nifty closed at 24,986.40, shedding 43.95 points, or 0.18%, from Friday's close. Both indices had last ended the Muhurat session lower in October 2017, when they fell 0.6% each.

Muhurat trading is a symbolic one-hour session in which domestic retail traders participate by making token transactions. Making money during the auspicious session is traditionally considered a good omen for the year ahead.

Despite the day's decline, market sentiment has shown signs of improving lately. The Nifty 50 gained more than 8% last week, its biggest weekly rise since February 2021. A correction in artificial intelligence-related stocks in the US and South Korea has also renewed investor interest in Indian equities.





NITIN SONAWANE

Investors at the special Muhurat trading session at BSE on Sunday

Foreign investors have turned buyers of domestic shares in recent days, with net purchases of $3.6 billion so far in November. This has reduced their net withdrawals for the year to $26.8 billion. The broader market outperformed the benchmarks. The BSE 150 MidCap index rose 0.4% to close at 16,447.27, while the BSE 250 SmallCap index gained 1.33% to end at 6,914.10.

Market breadth was positive, with rising stocks outnumbering declining ones on the BSE by 3,253 to 947, while 254 shares ended unchanged.

Among sectoral indices, Nifty Pharma led the gains, rising 1.7%. Nifty Metal and Nifty Cement advanced 0.4% each. Nifty Realty declined 0.7%, while Nifty Bank and Nifty IT fell 0.4% each. Nifty Consumer Durables shed 0.3%.

Indian equities remained volatile in Samvat 2082, with the Sensex and Nifty declining around 4% and 3%, respectively. Both indices saw their biggest decline since 2011. Trade-related concerns, elevated valuations, uncertainty over AI-related stocks and rising crude oil prices amid the US-Iran conflict weighed on sentiment. However, analysts expect Samvat 2083 to be relatively better, supported by easing geopolitical tensions and lower crude oil prices.

"There is a possibility of geopolitical tensions easing and crude oil prices remaining moderate over the next few months, which could support markets. However, volatility is likely to persist until there is greater clarity on the global political and policy environment," said Sunny Agrawal, head of fundamental retail research at SBICAPS Securities.

BANKS' UNHEDGED EXPOSURE SAID TO EXCEED $4 B

FCNR(B) Interest Bill to Keep Dollar Hedging Costs High

Rozebud Gonsalves

Mumbai: A multibillion-dollar FCNR(B) interest bill, coupled with the Reserve Bank of India's new reserve requirement on forex derivatives, is likely to keep dollar hedging costlier for Indian banks, treasury executives said.

While the RBI provided a hedging facility for the $133 billion raised for three to five years under the special window opened for mobilising foreign currency deposits, banks must bear the currency risk on interest payments to non-resident depositors.

At an average interest rate of 6.5-7.0%, the annual interest outgo on these deposits is estimated at $8.6 billion to $9.3 billion. At least half of this amount remains unhedged, according to treasury heads at six banks **ET** spoke with, leaving lenders with more than $4 billion in dollar exposure to manage annually.

"The interest on FCNR(B) deposits is not covered by the window. Banks have to buy those dollars forward themselves, year after year, in the open market," said Anindya Banerjee, head of currency research at Kotak Securities.

"A forward premium is simply the extra price one pays today to lock in dollars for delivery later. When the entire banking system is buying dollars forward for the same reason, and there are not enough natural sellers, that extra price goes up," Banerjee said.

Adding to the pressure is the RBI's new reserve requirement on banks' derivative positions. Introduced on October 10, the foreign exchange risk reserve (FERR) requires banks to maintain a cash reserve equivalent to 20% of the rupee value of eligible foreign-exchange derivative contracts.

FERR makes it more expensive for banks to offer certain forward-dollar hedges because they must lock away cash against the contracts. Banks may pass on part of this additional cost to customers, putting further pressure on forward premia. The one-month and one-year forward premia were 2.50% and 2.78%, respectively, in early August. They surged to 8.50% and 4.85% by mid-October before easing to 3.83% and 3.91% by November 6, reflecting near-term dollar demand.



A treasury head from a private bank said most banks had not put a hedging strategy in place as they were still assessing how best to manage this exposure. FERR in October added another layer of cost, making banks more cautious about locking in dollar liabilities over longer tenures. He explained that for now, the exposure was managed as it accrued, using short-term contracts that could be rolled over rather than hedging the entire interest obligation upfront. The reliance on short-term, rollover, contracts means banks will repeatedly return to the forward market as their interest liabilities accrue, sustaining demand for dollars instead of eliminating the exposure through an upfront hedge.

From Oct 10, FERR requires banks to maintain a cash reserve of 20% of the rupee value of eligible forex derivative contracts

Foreign banks, however, appear more comfortable carrying unhedged positions because they receive a steady stream of dollars from clients.

A treasury executive from a foreign bank said some banks might hedge in the coming days as the rupee appreciated.

The rupee staged a sharp recovery during the week, appreciating nearly 1.2% to close at 93.90 per dollar on Friday, its strongest level in more than six months.

Some midsize banks, meanwhile, hedged the bulk of their dollar exposure after costs fell within their internal thresholds.

WEDDING COSTS

Band, Baaja & Hidden Bills

Riju Mehta

Mikhil Gupta and Poulomy Dey had an entire year to plan their wedding. In January 2025, Gupta, a Mumbai-based chartered accountant, began tracking their expenses, set the spending caps for various heads, and arrived at a precise figure: ₹19 lakh. By the time the wedding took place on 14 February 2026, the couple had spent ₹25 lakh, overshooting the budget by nearly 32%.

It's an experience common to countless couples readying to tie the knot. They watch in dismay as a string of hidden, unexpected or unplanned expenses upends their wedding budgets. It could be due to vendors and service providers, whose initial quotes don't reveal the fine print; their own lack of research and due diligence on costs; family and peer pressure, which doesn't allow them to slash guest lists or cut costs on decor; inflation, which bloats all expenses. "A typical wedding budget exceeds the original estimate by 20-35%. The biggest jumps occur in décor, catering, guest hospitality and entertainment add-ons," says Nikita Dubey, co-founder & CEO, Shubhtithi Weddings.

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Budgeting is the firststep because it gives you room to make decisions that don't lead to scrambling for extra funds to cover shortfalls. "Couples should decide their priorities and divide the budget into major categories. Within each category, they should then identify what is non-negotiable, where they are open to alternatives, and what they can compromise on," says Shaanu Jain, Founder & CEO, The Wedding Toli India.

NBFCs Weigh Rate Hikes Amid Insurance Curbs

Borrowing costs to rise as lenders may turn to higher processing fees, lending margins

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: Non-bank lenders and housing finance companies are looking at increasing lending rates and loan processing fees besides changing their product mix to offset a potential decline in insurance distribution income under proposed regulatory caps, industry executives said.

The move could raise borrowing costs for some customers, particularly in affordable housing and other relatively high-yield lending segments where lenders have greater flexibility on loan pricing and fee corrections. Bajaj Housing Finance, for example, said it expects to recover part of the income loss through higher processing charges and lending margins in its affordable housing finance business Sambhav.

"In Sambhav segment, some offset will happen through the higher processing fees and a bit of a higher margin," managing director Atul Jain told analysts.

In its prime housing-loan business, however, the lender expects only part of the impact to be recoverable through higher fees, productivity improvements and operating efficiencies.

Home First Finance is similarly considering changes in loan pricing and fees alongside a shift in the product mix. "We have multiple levers to make up the 20 basis points," managing director Manoj Viswanathan said, referring to the residual impact the affordable housing financier expects after potential regulatory concessions. These include increasing the share of higher-yielding loans against property, undertaking more loan assignments and making "a slight change in the pricing or slight change in the fee," he said.



Home First Finance estimates that the proposed changes in insurance distribution business could reduce its return on assets by about 35 basis points before mitigation.

Insurance distribution has become an increasingly important source of fee income for non-bank lenders. An ICRA study of 10 large NBFCs and HFCs showed insurance distribution income was equivalent to 8% of NBFC profit after tax in FY26, up from just 0.8% in FY23. For housing financiers, it represented 7.6% of PAT, against about 1% three years earlier. The comparable share was 6.8% for private banks and around 2% for public sector banks.

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), in a recent consultation paper on recalibrating insurance distribution economics, has proposed steep cuts in commissions on credit-linked products, including a ceiling of 2% of premium for single-premium credit-life insurance and 2.5% in the first year for multi-year credit-life policies. For credit-linked health insurance distributed by lenders, the proposed cap is 5% on the first sale. At present, payouts on credit-linked insurance are determined through commercial arrangements between insurers and distributors. Single-premium credit-life policies carried an average commission of about 22% in FY25.

Ambiguity in Wordings

▸▸ From Page 1

In one of the largest cyber insurance claims, amounting to about ₹700 crore, forensic and legal expenses accounted for nearly 30% of the total cost, Bilgrami said.

For institutions handling large transaction volumes, even a brief disruption can lead to significant losses and costs related to system restoration, forensic investigations, technology consultants, customer communication and the replacement of compromised debit cards.

"Ransomware attacks, bricking, privacy and data breaches, as well as direct theft of money through cyberattacks, are the major drivers for NBFCs to seek increased cover," Saxena said.

Recent cyber incidents involving Bank of Baroda, State Bank of India, Central Bank of India and AU Small Finance Bank have brought the vulnerability of financial institutions into focus. Insurers have reported several attacks on financial services and manufacturing companies over the past three to four months. Investigations into some incidents are ongoing.

Insurers are increasingly concerned about hackers using artificial intelligence to identify vulnerabilities and breach IT systems. A deeper breach could expose customer KYC documents and financial records, increasing liabilities as well as the cost of notifying affected customers and monitoring compromised data.

LITTLE CHANGE IN POLICY TERMS

Despite the growing use of AI in cyberattacks, insurance policy wordings have not changed significantly. Policies generally cover the financial consequences of an incident, irrespective of whether it involves AI, a rogue employee or compromised data, subject to policy terms and exclusions. "Only a handful of insurers are currently asking specific questions and evaluating clients' AI exposure," Tata AIG's Bilgrami said, adding that underwriting discipline would be important as new risks emerge.

Policy wording itself remains a concern, with gaps between different sections of cover potentially complicating claims.

While the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, expected to be implemented in May 2027, could increase the financial consequences of data breaches, it has not yet triggered a significant rise in cyber insurance purchases, an industry executive said. Competition Keeps Premiums in Check

Despite rising threats and demand for higher limits, cyber insurance premiums have not increased, remaining around 0.75%-1.5% of the sum assured. A company buying ₹2,000 crore of cyber insurance cover, for instance, would typically pay an annual premium of about ₹15 crore-₹30 crore, depending on its risk profile, claims history and cybersecurity controls.

Gains Momentum

▸▸ From Page 1



Amazon Now and Flipkart Minutes are targeting a 30% year-on-year increase in sales during the Diwali period, following a slow start to the festive season, largely due to sluggish sales of mobiles and electronic goods, industry executives told ET.

To be sure, both companies had a smaller quick commerce presence than their rivals last year.

"Electronics, in particular, has emerged as one of our key growth categories, with select segments witnessing several-fold growth compared to the previous year," said a Bigbasket spokesperson.

Shopping for Diwali festivities began about a week before.

Flower orders rose 42%, pooja diyas grew 45%, and mithai orders grew 55% on Instamart last week from a year ago.

Between October 30 and November 5, Flipkart Minutes witnessed a threefold growth in orders, driven by festive essentials, home and kitchen, décor and gifting.

ET reported on November 2 that micro occasions such as Karva Chauth and Halloween drove a sharp increase in orders on quick commerce platforms, rapid fashion delivery apps and at-home beauty services.

A similar trend was visible during Dhanteras. "Typically, occasions like Dhanteras see a significant shift in shopping from offline markets to quick commerce," said Satish Meena, founder of market intelligence firm Datum Intelligence. "This surge in demand has led to products going out of stock by the middle of the day, as it is difficult to forecast demand at an individual SKU (stock-keeping unit) level."

SALES UPTICK

As gifting and festive shopping picked up pace in the last leg of the festive season during Diwali, brands in these categories saw multi-fold growth.

Brands like Pilgrim, Suta, Mars Cosmetics, Hilary Rhoda, EDT, Open Secret and others have seen a two- to three-fold growth in sales volume on quick commerce during the Diwali period.

"Quick commerce has emerged as our fastest-growing channel this festive season, recording almost 2x growth compared to the previous year and growing at nearly twice the pace of our overall ecommerce business," said a spokesperson at makeup brand Mars Cosmetics.

"This growth has been driven by wider dark store coverage, improved product availability and a stronger festive assortment across platforms."

Similarly, ethnic wear brand Suta saw 50% growth on quick commerce during Diwali.

"Three-four days before Diwali, we saw higher purchases and consumers turned to blouses and ready-to-wear sarees for last-minute orders," said founder Sujata Biswas.

ET reported on September 7 that quick commerce is expected to account for 16%, or ₹24,000 crore, of festive spending this year.

Ownership vs Authority

▸▸ From Page 1

While a trust beneficiary or foreign account signatory has to report these facts under the 'Foreign Assets' (FA) Schedule in the I-T Return (ITR), it's felt the same should not be extended to the scheme.

It's suggested that the Board (or CBDT) confirm that an account over which the taxpayer holds only signing authority, with no financial interest, is not an undisclosed foreign asset for the purpose of the scheme, said a member of The Chamber of Tax Consultants, which is among the bodies to reach out to CBDT. Similarly, a beneficiary of a foreign trust has to report the information in the ITR.

But some fear that disclosure under FAST-DS could bring them under the taxman's lens even if the beneficiary owns no trust asset or hasn't received funds from the trust. "In cases where undisclosed foreign income is credited to a foreign bank account, it's unclear whether the income or bank balance (asset) must be disclosed.

An FAQ under the 2015 Scheme suggested that the asset has to be disclosed. FAST-DS doesn't provide similar clarity. This is important as valuation of income and asset may differ. Another issue concerns foreign income on which Indian taxes have been paid but wasn't disclosed in Schedule FA," said Harshal Bhuta, co-founder and country co-head, international tax and FEMA, at Ascentium India. Also, in cases where tax payer holds a foreign account jointly with a spouse and has contributed a part of the funds, there's no mechanism for apportionment between joint holders.

An area of concern, says chartered accountant Ashish Karundia, relates to employees who inadvertently failed to report ESOPs in Schedule FA and subsequently didn't offer dividend income to tax, despite having paid tax on shares as salary perquisites.

"Such employees could face disproportionate and multiple layers of tax and compliance costs: withholding tax on dividends in overseas jurisdiction, a 60% levy in India for non-disclosure of dividend and a further ₹1 lakh for disclosure of underlying shares, irrespective of their value," said Karundia.

Under the scheme, the fair market value of every asset is determined as on March 31, 2026, a clause that dampened enthusiasm for the scheme, thanks to the rupee's slide against the dollar.

"Most are put off by the ₹1 crore limit, which today is a minuscule number. In the 2015 scheme, there was no limit. Many who are ready to pay and declare could not participate as the respective amounts breached ₹1 cr as per March 2026 value. Such a scheme should have higher limits of ₹100-200 crore to draw wider interest," said Rajesh Shah, partner at Jayantilal Thakkar, a Mumbai-based CA firm.

Wall Street Races for Megadeals as Countdown Begins on Trump Era

Conversations with top advisers suggest the result is already prompting companies to ask whether they should move fast to bring big strategic moves forward

Bloomberg: President Donald Trump's return to the White House changed the political calculus around mergers and acquisitions, reviving companies' desire for dream deals that had become difficult to pull off. Now, corporate America is on the clock.

The rout by the Democrats in the midterms is creating a sudden sense of urgency in boardrooms, with executives wondering if they might have one last chance to pull off a transformational transaction while M&A-friendly regulators remain in place under Trump.

Conversations with top advisers suggest the result is already prompting companies to ask whether they should move fast to bring big strategic moves forward. There's a realization that a resurgent Democratic Party could work to frustrate the kind of blockbuster dealmaking that's built up steam during Trump 2.0. and powered record revenue on Wall Street.



Kevin Foley, co-head of investment banking at JPMorgan Chase & Co., one of the world's top advisory firms, said companies should be ready to transact through another complicated operating environment.

"The biggest risk may be assuming that, sooner or later, things go back to normal," New York-based Foley said.

"Standing still is always an option, but when industries are changing this fast, it's the wrong one."

Fernando Rivas, a senior Wells Fargo & Co. banker, put it more starkly at an industry conference in Boston on Thursday when he said a "now or never" mentality will return to drive M&A in the near term. Trump's two terms have accounted for an outsized share of the biggest deals. More than half of all announced transactions worth at least $50 billion and involving a US company over the past two decades have come while he was president, according to analysis of Bloomberg-compiled data.

This year alone has seen landmark combinations in mission-critical sectors like power and technology, such as this month's record-breaking $100 billion-plus takeover of laser maker Lumentum Holdings Inc. by Marvell Technology Inc. Elsewhere, the Department of Justice cleared Paramount Skydance Corp.'s $110 billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery Inc. without antitrust remedies.

There's a particular urgency to get going with these more complex transactions. Megadeals can take months to negotiate and even longer to clear regulatory reviews around the world.

Companies that wait until a 2028 presidential campaign is in full swing to move ahead with such deals risk seeing them become political footballs at the stump.

"If you have a major transaction that is going to take time to put together and get through the process, you really have to start working on it now and probably announce it by the middle of 2027," said Paul Nary, assistant professor of management at the University of Pennsylvania's Wharton School.

"There isn't that much time left."

BALANCE SHIFT

A major test case for mega M&A in the new landscape could be the potential combination of Elon Musk's SpaceX and Tesla Inc., which would be among the biggest and most politically sensitive corporate tie-ups ever attempted and reveal the extent of the billionaire's influence with Trump as the balance of power in Washington begins to shift.

Bloomberg News has reported that Musk, who spent almost $500 million supporting Republican candidates in key midterm races, is pushing to announce a merger of his two largest companies by the first half of 2027.

But things have become more complicated; shares in both SpaceX and Tesla have slumped amid concerns that a Democrat-led Congress will probe Musk's business and political dealings and, more broadly, look to slow the artificial intelligence boom he has consistently championed.

Overall, India Inc Credit Profile Looks Healthy

ET Q&A

Corporate India's credit profile has held strong despite the geopolitical challenges and uncertainties in the last one year. However, higher inflation, oil prices and a weaker rupee could start hurting businesses and consumer confidence, said **Icra Group CEO Ramnath Krishnan** in an interview to **Joel Rebello**. Edited excerpts:

What is driving corporate India's strong credit quality despite volatility?

Post-Covid, corporates spent considerable time on deleveraging and improving liquidity, which has strengthened credit profiles across corporate India. Most companies remain in a good place. Icra continues to see roughly three rating upgrades for every downgrade, indicating corporate India's overall credit profile remains healthy despite stress in a few sectors, and that is unlikely to change significantly. While sectors such as chemicals, airlines, gems and jewellery, and oil & gas refining face pressure from geopolitical issues, and Icra has a negative outlook on these sectors, the agency does not see any major systemic crisis emerging.

If this crisis continues, do you see any pressure on the credit ratio?

It is confined to a few sectors, so we don't expect material change. But could it bring the credit ratio down by a few points? Possibly. Essentially, it's going to be a function of how long the war is going to last, and nobody has an answer to that. But there will be a lot of other collateral damage we need to be mindful of. There will be pressure on inflation. Now, our forecast for headline WPI is about 9% and CPI about 5%. If crude prices continue to remain at elevated levels, at $100 a barrel or beyond that, then there will definitely be pressure on inflation.



What are the headwinds for corporate credit as we speak?

International factors, inflation, and a weak rupee for corporates who have significant foreign currency exposure. Corporates have several things affecting their margins. Freight costs have gone up or will rise if the war persists. Input costs, and cost of borrowing, has gone up. All this will result in pressure on margins. They will not be able to pass on all these costs to the end consumer. But the fact is since all of them are sitting on a lot of liquidity, the impact is likely to be more manageable.

Don't you see the situation where companies are sitting on cash, but private investments have not really picked up?

Private sector capex has been muted for some years now and that's certainly a matter of big concern. Companies are reluctant to put money on the table until they get visibility into how the demand side of the equation is likely to pan out. Most of the investments in the last one year have been in the infrastructure space, power, ports, cement and so on. One can literally name the groups who have been putting money on the table. Outside of that, people are reluctant. At the semi-urban, urban segments of the economy, it's fair to say that there is some element of stress.

How do Icra's revenue components shape up?

We have got two broad components, ratings and the non-ratings risk & analytics (R&A) business. We do a lot of work for overseas clients through a GCC like model. We have three entities in the R&A space, Icra Analytics, D2K Technologies, which we acquired three years ago, and Fintellix, which we completed recently. We do financial analysis, bond valuation, data analysis and risks analytics for the BFSI sector. Now, the GCC business contributes 60% to our risk analytics business. Overall, currently the risk analytics business contributes between 46%, and 54% of revenues comes from the ratings business. In terms of growth risk and analytics is our focus because it's a specialised business and there is a lot of flexibility on what we can do. In terms of revenue, the mix may change in the medium term because the ratings business is tied to the economy.

THE VIEW Says further hikes depend on the economy sustaining its resilience

BoE's Pill Sees Scope for Interest Rate Cuts if UK Growth Stalls

Bloomberg



Bank of England chief economist Huw Pill said interest rates may remain steady or even decline if the UK economy's growth spurt stalls next year. He said the decision to raise rates a quarter-point to 4% on Thursday was "preemptive" rather than based on evidence that inflation is spreading widely across the economy.

The Monetary Policy Committee was forced into action by a worsening energy shock but it also pointed to a resilient economy after a string of surprisingly strong growth figures. Financial markets see a 60% chance of a follow-up hike next month and are betting on at least two increases over the next 12 months. However, Pill, one of the most hawkish BoE officials, raised the possibility that further rate rises could be avoided if the economy finally buckles under pressure from another cost-of-living crisis.

"There is a possibility that bank rate remains on hold or even falls were we to see a stalling of growth in the economy, a weakening of the threat of second-round effects," he said in an online briefing on Friday. "There are these upside risks stemming from energy and so forth, but there are also question marks about whether this resilience we've seen in the economy, in both growth and employment, will be sustained."

The MPC unanimously backed raising rates for the first time in over three years and signalled that more are likely if the Iran war drags on. However, the situation is changing rapidly with oil and gas prices plunging this week after the crushing defeat for the Republican party in the US midterm elections raised hopes of an end to the conflict.

While figures next week are expected to show the economy grew a robust 0.7% in the third quarter, there are already signs that households may be starting to tighten their belts with domestic energy bills set to leap by a quarter in January. Economists were caught off guard by the surge in GDP in 2026. The BoE has predicted the economy will grow 1.6% this year, the strongest expansion in four years, but it expects momentum to ease in 2027 and 2028 as pressure on consumers and businesses builds.

Pill ruled out a repeat of the aggressive rate increases experienced after the 2022 inflation shock, adding that the scale of the energy price increase is smaller than after Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

TIME OF STRESS Rain deficit raises risks, with gross NPAs at 5.1% against 1.8% system-wide

Agri Loans Grow as Biggest Asset-Quality Risk for Indian Banks

Sangita Mehta

Mumbai: Agricultural loans have emerged as the biggest asset-quality risk for Indian banks, with the segment's bad-loan ratio far exceeding those of industry, services and retail despite a broader improvement in loan books.

The gross non-performing asset ratio for agricultural loans stood at 5.1% in the second quarter of 2026, compared with 1.5% each for industry and services and 1% for retail loans, according to BMI Research, an arm of Fitch Group. The system-wide gross NPA ratio declined to 1.8%, making farm credit the clearest stress point in an otherwise healthier banking system, BMI said.

Agricultural bad loans have declined from more than 10% during 2020-21, but the segment remains a clear outlier. The vulnerability has increased after India's southwest monsoon ended 12.6% below its long-period average, marking the weakest rainfall since 2015.

At Bank of Baroda, agricultural NPAs rose 11.6% year on year to ₹9,128 crore and accounted for 34% of total slippages during the quarter. However, MD and CEO Debadatta Chand told analysts that the bank had not seen any signs of stress so far.

Canara Bank reported agricultural loan slippages of ₹687 crore, accounting for nearly 37% of the total of ₹1,844 crore in second-quarter slippages. Its exposure to drought-prone areas stood at about ₹13,900 crore, MD and CEO Brijesh Kumar told analysts.

Kumar said the entire exposure was unlikely to come under stress as the State Level Bankers' Committees could offer relief to affected agricultural borrowers through measures such as restructuring or a moratorium. "Some kind of dispensation comes every time," he said.

Punjab National Bank said agricultural loans classified as Special Mention Account-2, or SMA-2, declined to ₹89 crore from ₹314 crore a year ago. SMA-2 accounts are those in which repayments are overdue by more than 60 days and up to 90 days.

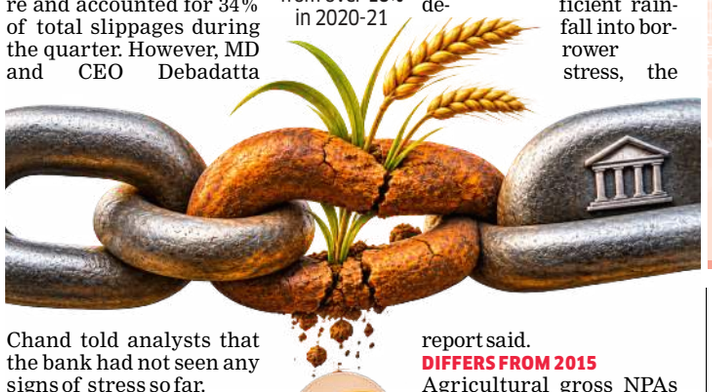
MD and CEO Ashok Chandra said PNB had not seen stress but remained "mindful" of the drought situation. The bank has put in place a large-scale programme to connect with farmers and monitor conditions on the ground, he said.

"Things are fully under control. There is no alarm button to be pushed now," Chandra said.

THE WEAK LINK

Agriculture has the highest gross NPA ratio among major loan segments

Agricultural bad loans have declined from over **10%** in 2020-21



Other major lending segments have considerably lower NPA ratios

BMI sees limited risk to overall banking asset quality

Lower farm incomes could weaken borrowers' repayment capacity and add to agricultural loan arrears, particularly as the segment already carries relatively high credit risk. However, the stress may take time to appear in banks' reported numbers because the classification of agricultural loans as non-performing is linked to crop seasons, the BMI report said.

BMI, however, does not expect the weak monsoon to cause a material deterioration in system-wide asset quality.

The principal kharif crop has already been harvested, while the rabi crop is less dependent on southwest monsoon rainfall. Greater irrigation coverage, government food buffers and more diversified rural incomes should also limit the transmission of deficient rainfall into borrower stress, the report said.

DIFFERS FROM 2015

Agricultural gross NPAs stood at 4.6% in the first quarter of 2015 before rising gradually and eventually exceeding 10% during 2019-21. But BMI said similarly weak monsoons in 2015 and 2026 should not be taken to imply a comparable increase in system-wide bad loans.

The previous deterioration was driven primarily by a corporate bad-loan cycle rather than agricultural stress. The gross NPA ratio for industry loans rose from 6.2% in the first quarter of 2015 to 22.5% in the first quarter of 2018, sharply worsening asset quality across the banking system. Banks are entering the current period with stronger capital and earnings buffers. The banking sector's total capital ratio stood at 18% in the first quarter of 2026, while its common equity tier-1 ratio was 15.1% and return on assets reached 2%.

TECHNICAL VIEWS

Nifty Eyes 25,600 After Sharp Rally; 'Buy on Dips'

The Nifty gained over 8.5% during the week, rising more than 2,500 points from 22,500 and reclaiming the 25,000 mark. Analysts see further upside towards 25,300-25,600, although elevated volatility and overbought conditions could trigger a brief consolidation. Buying on dips remains the preferred strategy.

CHANDAN TAPARIA

HEAD – DERIVATIVES & TECHNICALS, WEALTH MANAGEMENT, **MOTILAL OSWAL FINANCIAL SERVICES**

The Nifty has formed higher highs and higher lows over the last seven sessions, supported by a strong bullish weekly candle. Having crossed resistance at 24,444-24,600, the index could extend its rally towards 25,350 and 25,600 as long as it holds above this zone. Key support is placed at 24,000.

Nifty Strategy:
For the November 23, 2026, expiry, adopt a bull call spread by buying one lot of the 25,000 call and selling one lot of the 25,500 call. The maximum risk is 180 points (₹11,700 per lot), while the maximum profit potential is 320 points (₹20,800 per lot).

TOP STOCKS THIS WEEK

Adani Ports: Buy | CMP: ₹1,936 | Target: ₹2,050 | Stop loss: ₹1,875
A breakout above ₹1,875 on the daily and weekly charts, expanding volumes and buying interest on declines indicate strengthening momentum.

MCX: Buy | CMP: ₹3,528 | Target: ₹3,700 | Stop loss: ₹3,435
The stock remains in a strong uptrend, respecting its 10-month EMA. Bullish RSI readings and rising volumes indicate sustained buying interest.

DHARMESH SHAH

HEAD – TECHNICAL, **ICICI SECURITIES**

The Nifty has broken out of an eight-month falling trendline, recovering its entire 12-week decline in two weeks and prompting a revision of the target to 25,500. However, the sharp rally has pushed momentum indicators into overbought territory, making brief consolidation possible. The index has formed a double bottom after defending its 200-week EMA. Market breadth has improved, with 58% of Nifty 50 stocks trading above their 200-day moving averages. Support has shifted higher to 24,300.

Nifty Strategy:
Use declines towards 24,400–24,500 as buying opportunities, with a target of 25,000. Immediate support is at 24,180.

TOP STOCKS THIS WEEK

Larsen & Toubro: Buy | CMP: ₹4,119 | Target: ₹4,520 | Stop loss: ₹3,798
A breakout above a falling trendline joining the February and June 2026 highs signals an end to the corrective phase. The stock has recovered its entire nine-week decline in two weeks.

SBI: Buy | CMP: ₹1,018 | Target: ₹1,129 | Stop loss: ₹929
A double bottom near the 100-week EMA signals buying demand, while polarity reversal and 50% retracement offer favourable risk-reward.



NILESH JAIN

HEAD – EQUITY TECHNICAL & DERIVATIVE RESEARCH, **CENTRUM FINVERSE**

The Nifty extended its winning streak to seven sessions and closed above 25,000. A sustained move above this level could take it towards 25,300–25,500, while the 200-day moving average near 24,000 remains key support. India VIX surged nearly 14% to 17.58, indicating elevated volatility and warranting caution against aggressive long positions. Bank Nifty continues to show a relatively stronger technical structure.

Bank Nifty Strategy:
Adopt a bull call spread for the monthly expiry by buying one lot of the 59,200 call at ₹694 and selling one lot of the 59,800 call at ₹466. The net debit is 228 points, with maximum loss of ₹6,840 and maximum profit potential of ₹11,160 per lot. The breakeven is 59,428.

TOP STOCKS THIS WEEK

HDFC Life: Buy | CMP: ₹563 | Target: ₹609 | Stop loss: ₹540
A breakout from a falling channel, recovery above the 21-day and 50-day moving averages near `537, and above-average volumes support the bullish setup.

Bajaj Auto: Buy | CMP: ₹10,910 | Target: ₹12,000 | Stop loss: ₹10,300
The stock has formed a strong base and reclaimed its 100-day moving average at `10,870. Trading above the 200-day moving average at `10,180, along with healthy volumes, indicates a positive technical structure.

Policy Doctor: Health Insurance Guide



SEGAR SAMPATHKUMAR

FORMER INSURANCE OMBUDSMAN, CHENNAI

My employer-sponsored group health insurance policy, which covers my parents, was exhausted mid-year due to my mother's surgery. As a result, I will not be able to claim her pre- and post-hospitalisation expenses under my policy. However, she is also covered under my sister's corporate health insurance plan. Can my sister claim these pre- and post-hospitalisation expenses under her policy?

Most health insurance policies in India do not cover such treatment expenses unless they are anchored to a hospitalisation claim as pre- and post-hospitalisation expenses. To the extent that these expenses are in the nature of outpatient treatment, such as the purchase of medicines, diagnostic tests and physiotherapy services, they might not be admissible under your sister's policy. However, such expenses can be claimed under two circumstances. First, if your sister's corporate health insurance policy covers outpatient treatment. Second, certain procedures, such as angiography, colonoscopy, chemotherapy and dialysis, are generally covered as day-care procedures. If any of the expenses you have incurred relate to such day-care procedures, they may be covered under your sister's policy.

I am shortly scheduled to undergo radiation therapy for laryngeal cancer. My health insurance policy comes with room-rent sub-limits. Will these reduce my eligible claim amount, despite radiation therapy being a day-care procedure?

No. Room-rent limits in health insurance policies are meant to regulate expenditure on hospital room rent and other associated charges. Since radiation therapy does not require hospital admission, these sub-limits will not apply and should not have a bearing on your health insurance claim.

Have a health insurance query? Write to us at etwealth@timesofindia.com

AI Trade Fallout Puts India, China Back in Focus

VALUE HUNT Easing inflation and trade tensions could offer fresh opportunities as investors diversify their portfolios

Bloomberg

The unravelling of the AI trade after the US midterm elections is forcing investors to rethink their Asia playbook, reviving demand for out-of-favor Chinese and Indian stocks as well as companies poised to benefit from easing inflation and trade tensions.

Aberdeen Investments favours markets powered by stronger domestic growth, including India and Vietnam, and sees upside in Chinese technology firms. Hedge fund Lotus Asset Management is long Hong Kong equity futures, while Allianz Global Investors is looking at healthcare and consumer companies.

Asia has been among the hardest hit by the market fallout from the Democrats' sweep of Congress. Many of the region's biggest stocks — from Samsung Electronics Co. and SK Hynix Inc. to Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. — are critical suppliers to the global AI build-out, leaving local markets especially exposed as investors brace for greater scrutiny of the industry and question whether massive spending on computing infrastructure will generate sufficient returns.

"I expect investors to diversify more broadly and reduce their concentration in the AI trade," said Rajeev De Mello, global macro portfolio manager at Gama Asset Management SA. "This should be supportive of China and other markets where valuations are less demanding."

India could also benefit, although its dependence on imported energy remains a headwind, he added.

CHINA AND INDIA AS HEDGES

Hao Hong, chief investment officer at Lotus, said he is betting against oil and petrochemical firms and going long precious metals and Hong Kong equity futures.



A Hong Kong gauge tracking mainland companies gained 5.2% last week, its best performance since March 2025. Meanwhile, some global investors are interested in using China's onshore market exposure as a diversifier to their AI-heavy portfolio, according to Jason Lui, head of Asia-Pacific equity and derivatives strategy at BNP Paribas SA.

India's appeal, meanwhile, has grown as oil prices declined on expectations of an earlier end to the Iran war, easing a key pressure point for the energy-importing economy. The market's lack of AI exposure is also now seen as an advantage.

LOGOS Asset Management's chief investment officer Charlie Hong said he sold his shares in SK Hynix, Samsung Electronics, Intel and Lumentum Holdings last month and has since boosted his Indian holdings with shares of new-age tech companies, financial firms and contract drug manufacturers.

India's benchmark Nifty 50 gained 8.6% last week. registering its best week since 2021, as overseas investors returned in force. Foreign funds poured a net $1.9 billion into local shares last week through Wednesday.

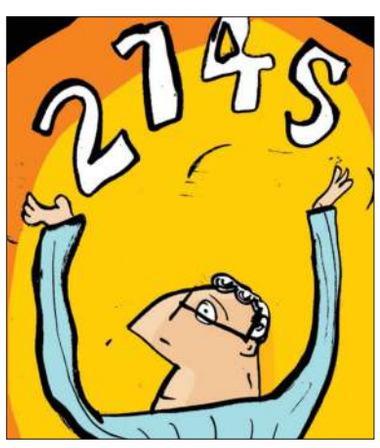
The sudden shift has kept market participants busy. Utkarsh Singh, a Mumbai-based senior manager at SBI-SG Global Securities, started taking calls from clients in Singapore as early as 6:30 a.m. Friday and continued fielding queries late into the day as Indian stocks rallied.

NPS Scorecard

National Pension System (NPS) helps you to save tax in several ways. There are only Ten NPS fund managers at present and the table below compares their performance. The data has been provided exclusively to ET.

TIER I: **Equity Plans**

Fund	NAV	Returns (%)			Assets (₹ cr)
		1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	
ABSL Pension Scheme	29.57	1.18	11.22	9.43	3019.57
Axis Pension Fund	14.66	-1.48	10.01	-	7430.46
DSP Pension Fund	12.99	-2.32	-	-	3466.60
HDFC Pension Fund	55.19	-0.46	11.44	9.25	80756.61
ICICI Pru Pension Fund	75.81	0.86	12.14	10.12	31743.05
Kotak Pension Fund	68.98	-1.60	11.41	9.85	4608.57
LIC Pension Fund	45.85	-0.91	10.54	9.13	7417.75
SBI Pension Fund	57.38	0.34	9.15	8.16	29059.86
Tata Pension Management	16.50	1.10	12.80	-	4155.69
UTI Pension Fund	73.10	-1.00	12.02	9.82	5581.71
BSE 200 Total Return Index	-	-1.82	11.49	9.15	-



TIER I: **Government Bond Plans**

Fund	NAV	Returns (%)			Assets (₹ cr)
		1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	
ABSL Pension Scheme	19.58	2.90	6.78	6.09	3765.43
Axis Pension Fund	12.93	2.78	6.39	-	7871.19
DSP Pension Fund	11.90	2.42	-	-	2427.57
HDFC Pension Fund	28.77	2.65	6.30	5.66	57601.33
ICICI Pru Pension Fund	38.82	3.27	6.62	5.85	24702.51
Kotak Pension Fund	38.21	2.58	6.05	5.57	2922.62
LIC Pension Fund	31.41	2.71	6.68	5.96	9369.94
SBI Pension Fund	42.12	2.89	6.75	5.94	31983.48
Tata Pension Management	12.98	2.24	6.15	-	2708.59
UTI Pension Fund	37.60	2.79	6.69	6.00	4508.56

TIER I: **Corporate Debt Plans**

Fund	NAV	Returns (%)			Assets (₹ cr)
		1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	
ABSL Pension Scheme	20.51	2.97	7.06	6.26	2140.23
Axis Pension Fund	13.18	3.41	7.09	-	5349.47
DSP Pension Fund	12.17	3.59	-	-	1589.46
HDFC Pension Fund	30.80	3.53	7.43	6.53	37053.55
ICICI Pru Pension Fund	46.56	3.97	7.41	6.45	15287.07
Kotak Pension Fund	44.68	4.08	7.40	6.37	1803.55
LIC Pension Fund	29.77	3.25	7.00	6.08	4654.74
SBI Pension Fund	46.64	3.71	7.39	6.37	17077.54
Tata Pension Management	13.15	2.97	7.13	-	1865.88
UTI Pension Fund	41.25	3.78	7.30	6.31	2606.39

Returns as on Nov 06, 2026. Assets as on Sep 30, 2026 Source: **Value Research**

NSE Looks Beyond Transaction Fees to Drive Growth

CAS-related disruption and lower transaction charges hit September-quarter revenue, prompting a push into newer segments

Sachin Kumar

ET Intelligence Group: NSE's revenue and profit declined sequentially in the September quarter, hit by changes in trading patterns following the implementation of CAS (Closing Auction Session) and a 16% drop in transaction charges. The next phase of growth is likely to come from recovery in trading volumes supported by CAS-related normalisation and its diversification into newer businesses such as commodity derivatives, digital gold products, mutual fund transactions and monetisation of data services.

Earnings Review

NSE's transaction-charge revenue declined sequentially to ₹3,035 crore in the September quarter from ₹3,623 crore in the June quarter. The fall was due to lower trading activity amid the CAS rollout in August. The new mechanism triggered greater price volatility towards the end of each trading day, prompting intraday equity and options traders to scale back activity.

NSE expects the amendments to the CAS framework, likely to take effect in December, to help expand market activity. While declaring first quarterly earnings as a listed company, the management said the CAS changes are expected to provide greater clarity on the settlement of expiring index options and support higher trading activity.

Quarter in Numbers

NSE's September quarter performance

₹ cr

	Sep'26	Jun'26	Sep'25	QoQ % change	YoY % change
Revenue from operations	4,067	**4,560**	3,677	**-10.8**	10.6
Operating Ebitda	3,079	**3,594**	1,484	**-14.3**	107.5
Ebitda Margin (%)	76	**79**	40	**-300 bps**	3600 bps
Net Profit	2,578	**3,120**	2,098	**-17.4**	22.9

bps: Basis points (100 bps= One percentage point) Source: Company data, ETIG
Ebitda: Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation and Amortisation

The exchange has also taken steps to diversify beyond the core transaction-fee business. It expects to launch corporate bond index futures after getting an approval from the Reserve Bank of India. This will open up a new avenue in fixed-income derivatives segment.

The company is looking to monetise its data offerings through Market Lens, its platform for providing curated datasets and analytics to market participants. The exchange plans to seek user feedback and add more datasets over the coming weeks and months. It will initially offer the service free of charge but may introduce a nominal fee to cover the cost of making the data available and simplifying it for investors.

NSE will promote Electronic Gold Receipts (EGRs) by making them easier for investors to access and trade. The exchange plans to set up collection centres where investors can deposit domestic gold and convert it into EGRs. PL Capital has maintained an 'Accumulate' rating on the stock. The broking firm has raised revenue and net profit estimates by 2.3% and 2.7% for FY27 and by 1.4% and 1.6% for FY28 in that order. It has assigned a target price of ₹1,950. The stock gained 7% in four trading sessions following the quarterly result declaration on November 3 to end the Muhurat-day trading at ₹1,930.5 on Sunday.

US Inflation Set to Simmer Down Some After Recent Pickup

Bloomberg

Prices for US goods and services probably rose at a slower pace in October after two particularly uncomfortable months for American consumers. The consumer price index is seen rising 0.3% after a 0.6% increase that was the largest since April, based on the median projection in a Bloomberg survey of economists ahead of Tuesday's Bureau of Labor Statistics' release.

The core measure, which excludes often-volatile energy and food components, also probably cooled. The survey median sees a 0.2% increase for October, which would be the smallest advance in three months. The agency won't publish year-over-year figures after it skipped the October 2025 CPI release due to the federal government shutdown at the time.



Sustained employment growth has the potential of ensuring consumers keep spending

The October CPI will be the last before the Federal Reserve's meeting in December, at which investors expect policymakers to boost interest rates. Economists will also assess the finer details of the report for clues on inflation risks into early 2027.

Economists at Citigroup said in a recent note that they anticipate limited pass-through of high energy costs to goods prices, as well as moderate services inflation.

The latest snapshot of inflation also follows Friday's stronger-than-expected October jobs report. Sustained employment growth has the potential of ensuring consumers keep spending, while allowing Fed to keep its focus squarely on inflation. Another price report, due on Friday, is projected to show nagging inflationary pressures faced by companies. The producer price index is forecast to accelerate to 6.6% for the year through October, the steepest annual increase in nearly four years.

Aside from inflation reports, National Association of Realtors figures Thursday are expected to show a decline in contract closings on previously owned homes to the lowest level since 2010.

Wheat Prices Hit Lowest Since June Ahead of Black Sea Peace Talks



Bloomberg

Wheat futures touched the lowest since the end of June as traders anticipate next week's planned US-led talks with delegations from Ukraine and Russia.

Futures fell as much as 2.4% to the lowest intraday price since June 30, before paring losses.

"Scheduled Black Sea talks in Abu Dhabi mid-next week are pressuring prices and that is likely to continue for the next few sessions," the Hightower Report said in a note.

The conflict has damaged ports amid escalating strikes in the Black Sea region, and disrupted exports of wheat from

GRAIN MARKETS

Black Sea export disruptions persist, while hopes of a peace deal put pressure on grain prices

Russia and Ukraine, two of the world's biggest suppliers of the grain. Recent talks with US envoys have raised hopes about making progress toward ending the war, which is now in its fifth year, but some remain skeptical about the prospect of peace between the two countries.

AgResource, in a Friday note, said it "fears that ending the Russian/Ukraine war will be complex and more difficult than what President Trump indicates." Elsewhere, the US Department of Agriculture on Friday reported export sales of 136,000 tons of soybeans to China, which appears to be closing in on this year's target to purchase 25 million tons from the US. The Asian nation has agreed to secure that amount annually through 2028, and has made a steady stream of purchases toward the goal since early July.

MAHINDRA AND OTHER AUTOMAKERS LOOK TO TAP THE GROWING MARKET

India's Three-Wheeler Market Makes a Decisive Electric Turn

Falling battery costs, govt incentives, fuel savings are accelerating adoption across nation

AFP



Every 90 seconds, an electric three-wheeler rolls off the production line at an Indian factory, underscoring a transformation that has made the country the largest market for battery-powered auto rickshaws.

At a bustling plant run by Mahindra Last Mile Mobility (LMM), workers and robots fit cells into battery packs, attach body panels to metal frames and fix wheels into place, racing to meet demand for vehicles known for navigating the chaotic streets of the world's most populous country.

In September, more than one in two new three-wheelers sold in India was electric, compared with about 8.5% of cars and 11.6% of two-wheelers, reaffirming its position as the world's largest electric three-wheeler market.

"Our company has grown six times in its EV penetration in the last five years," said Mahindra LMM's chief executive Suman Mishra.

She said adoption accelerated over the past two years as government subsidies, improving vehicle quality and falling operating costs combined to make ownership more attractive.

E-rickshaws first appeared on New Delhi's streets more than a decade ago, often assembled in roadside workshops using Chinese-made batteries fitted to modified pedal-powered tricycles.

But the sector has since eaten into the market for sturdier fossil-fuel-powered three-wheelers, becoming a major industry as manufacturers such as Mahindra expand their share.

The shift has altered the look and sound of Indian cities. Across northern India, e-rickshaws now queue outside railway stations and bustling markets, replacing the thumping noise of traditional "tuk-tuks".

FUEL SAVINGS

Mahindra is one of 15 finalists shortlisted for the environmental Earthshot Prize, to be awarded in Mumbai by Prince William on November 17.

For many drivers, however, earnings outweigh the environmental benefits. "Money is coming straight into my pocket," said Afroz Alam, a 31-year-old driver in Hyderabad who switched from a gas-powered model to an EV this year.

The cost of charging his vehicle saves him several hundred rupees a day, helping him repay the loan he took out to buy the more expensive electric version. "It may seem expensive, but then it levels out with the gas money you no longer have to pay," he told AFP.

Analysts agree economics is the key driver of adoption, with falling battery costs and rising fuel prices widening the advantage of e-vehicles. Indian think-tank CEEW estimated in 2025 that petrol three-wheelers cost more than twice as much per kilometre to operate over their lifetime as EVs.

A RELUCTANT TRANSITION

Japan's Deflation Legacy Makes Price Hikes a Hard Sell

Businesses struggle to pass on rising costs without upsetting cost-sensitive buyers

AFP



When Japan's "symbol of affordability", Uniqlo, decided to raise the price of its basic socks last month, it sparked a backlash before the clothing titan made an immediate U-turn. That came after Italian-style family restaurant chain Saizeriya issued an almost grovelling apology as it decided to add ¥20 ($0.13) to the price of its trademark Milanese Doria, lamenting its "lack of effort".

The very public angst, including at one of the world's most recognisable clothing brands, highlights the struggles Japanese firms face as they battle rising costs in a country where decades of deflation have nurtured a consumer class averse to higher prices.

The Bank of Japan last month declared that its 2% inflation target had been met, after 13 years of ultra-loose monetary policy.

Measures unveiled in 2013 by then-prime minister Shinzo Abe — and continued by successive governments — were supposed to end a spiral of deflation that had plagued Japan for decades since the mid-1990s.

However, it wasn't until 2022 — when the Ukraine war triggered a global energy shock — that inflation began to flicker back to life in resource-poor Japan.

Then the US-Israel war on Iran saw Tehran choke off the strategic Strait of Hormuz, slashing crude exports from the Middle East and impacting global supply chains, in turn sending company costs soaring.

While firms in most countries have been able to lift prices accordingly — albeit to expected anger — those in Japan have to contend with an ingrained view that hikes are taboo. Businesses big and small have found themselves hard-pressed to plough ahead with drastic price hikes to avoid alienating customers.

Decisive increases can pose a greater risk to smaller, countryside businesses, whose survival often hinges on loyal patronage from regular clients.

Uniqlo's decision to row back on its sock price hike came as it sought to protect its status as paragon of affordability portrayed in local media.

Saizeriya, whose price increases went far beyond Doria and covered almost all menu items, issued a statement some saw as self-flagellating. The company's president even vowed at a news conference to "look for any excuses to lower prices again", to the amazement of social media users.

'INSANELY HIGH'

Soaring grocery bills have left Japanese households less room to spend on other purchases, from dining out to clothing, even as these businesses grapple with rising labour and material costs of their own. This is despite recent labour ministry statistics showing real wages in Japan have increased year-on-year for eight consecutive months.

To make matters worse, the Bank of Japan has embarked on a period of interest rate increases to battle inflation, with borrowing costs at a more than 30-year high and likely to go up again.

BOE's Huw Pill Says Interest Rates Could Be Cut If Growth Stalls

Bloomberg

Bank of England Chief Economist Huw Pill said interest rates may remain steady or even decline if the UK economy's growth spurt stalls next year.

He said the decision to raise rates a quarter-point to 4% on Thursday was "preemptive" rather than based on evidence that inflation is spreading widely across the economy.

The Monetary Policy Committee was forced into action by a worsening energy shock but it also pointed to a resilient economy after a string of surprisingly strong growth figures.

Financial markets see a 60% chance of a follow-up hike next month and are betting on at least two increases over the next 12 months.

However, Pill, one of the most hawkish BOE officials, raised the possibility that further rate rises could be avoided if the economy finally buckles under pressure from another cost-of-living crisis.

"There is a possibility that bank rate remains on hold or even falls were we to see a stalling of growth in the economy, a weakening of the threat of second-round effects," he said in an online briefing on Friday. "There are these upside risks stemming from energy and so forth, but there are also question marks about whether this resilience we've seen in the economy, in both growth and employment, will be sustained."

The MPC unanimously backed raising rates for the first time in over three years and signaled that more are likely if the Iran war drags on. However, the situation is changing rapidly with oil and gas prices plunging this week after the crushing defeat for the Republican party in the US midterm elections raised hopes of an end to the conflict.

While figures next week are expected to show the economy grew a robust 0.7% in the third quarter, there are already signs that households may be starting to tighten their belts with domestic energy bills set to leap by a quarter in January.

BOE expects UK economic growth to slow in 2027, 2028 as pressure on households, businesses builds

Economists were caught off guard by the surge in GDP in 2026.

The BOE has predicted the economy will grow 1.6% this year, the strongest expansion in four years, but it expects momentum to ease in 2027 and 2028 as pressure on consumers and businesses builds.

Pill ruled out a repeat of the aggressive rate increases experienced after the 2022 inflation shock, adding that the scale of the energy price increase is smaller than after Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

"There is a sort of preemptive character to the decision yesterday," Pill said. "Whether we see one more rate hike or not, that will play out over the next few weeks."

Dutchman and Spaniard in Last Lap of Race for ECB Chief Post

Bloomberg

The choice for European Central Bank President Christine Lagarde's successor probably comes down to Dutchman Klaas Knot and Spaniard Pablo Hernandez de Cos.

The Netherlands and Spain each nominated their former central-bank chiefs to replace Lagarde when she departs in February, Kyriakos Pierrakakis, who heads the group of euro-area finance ministers, said Friday in a statement. De Cos currently leads the Bank for International Settlements.

"At its next meeting on 9 November, the Eurogroup will take stock of these candidacies," the group said. While no other candidate was proposed before Friday's deadline of 5 p.m. in Brussels, a surprise late-stage contender could yet appear once political bargaining starts in earnest, just like Lagarde did in 2019.

Her position is part of what Greece's prime minister has called a "grand bargain," including the jobs of Executive Board member Isabel Schnabel and Chief Economist Philip Lane, with the former leaving the ECB early in January 2027 and the latter in May, when his eight-year term ends.

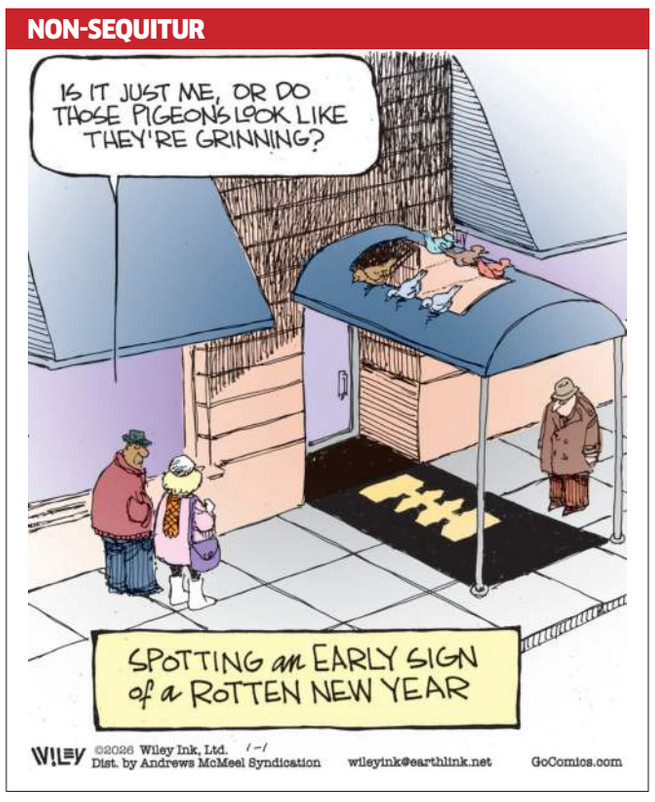
That will be one of the biggest reshuffles of the six-strong board since the institution's inception more than 25 years ago. If Knot were to become president, it would even involve a fourth job as his fellow countryman Frank Elderson would have to leave.

The changes come at a delicate time, with inflation running at double the ECB's 2% target and fiscal stress worrying investors in France. While the euro zone's 21 finance ministers will assess candidates on Monday, the final decision rests with European leaders. That puts the spotlight on an informal summit scheduled for Nov. 13 and a special one on Nov. 26-27.

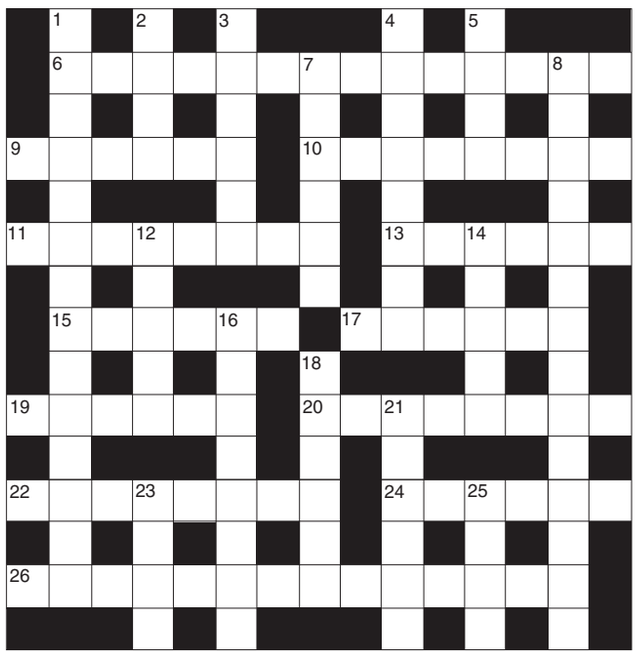
Crucial to the selection will be an agreement between the leaders of the region's two biggest economies, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and French President Emmanuel Macron. Both countries are looking to maintain their presence on the ECB board, with Spain also pushing for a seat after Vice President Luis de Guindos retired earlier this year.

France appears keen to get Lane's position and is well prepared. It can pick from candidates including Bank of France Deputy Governor Agnès Bénassy-Quéré and former OECD official Laurence Boone.

NON-SEQUITUR



Crossword 9751



ACROSS
6 What Dr. Greenfinch drizzled over brassica heart? (6,8)
9 Master upset group of schoolchildren (6)
10 PM supporter could become irritable with radical (8)
11 Monument in Rome on way back occupies Liam oddly (8)
13 Objective: camping (6)
15 Yearn to be back eating a grand Scottish dish (6)
17 Bizarre person in Irish party we introduced (6)
19 Question on variety of guano debated by this body? (6)
20 Ex-Tory leader grabs setter, heading back to base (8)
22 Recommend a time to allow in very old catholic (8)
24 4, when worked up about record (6)
26 Sharers and dealers gather for final run-through (5,9)

DOWN
1 Time he ought to probe bid – it's revealing (3,3,8)
2 Party's downfall, say (4)
3 Sea food I misplaced somehow, leaving deli (6)
4 Kinsman's musical, brought up on dance (not European) (8)
5 Leader involved in drastic upheaval (4)
7 English pound offer taken up for garden tool (6)
8 Distribute nylon outer only? No way! (3,2,4,5)
12 Instrument's in newspaper, for instance (5)
14 Is chair cover worth repairing? (5)
16 Adroitly orchestrated total devotion (8)
18 Cereal farmers do, exploiting the hours contracted (6)
21 He's mad to plunder main account (6)
23 Evict judge forsaking old contest (4)
25 Tops of phlox, orchid, scabious and yarrow? (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9750:
ACROSS: 1 Put-down. **5** Abrupt. **9** Careers. **10** Tendons. **11** Eye. **12** Francophone. **13** Spore. **14** Footprint. **16** Lunchtime. **17** Munch. **19** Action plans. **22** Odd. **23** Earthen. **24** Lateral. **26** Osiery. **27** Nemesis.
DOWN: 1 Packers. **2** Three-point turns. **3** Ode. **4** Nesta. **5** Artichoke. **6** Run-up. **7** Promotion boards. **8** Aspect. **12** Flesh. **14** Flippancy. **15** Pumps. **16** Loaves. **18** Huddles. **20** Ochre. **21** All in. **25** Tim.

©The Daily Mail

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 60 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally:

	46	45	39		37	36	
						30	
49				41			33
	50						32
51	53					25	
		1		60	15		24
	4		8	11		16	
		9			13		18

www.hidato.com Dif. ★★★☆☆

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Yesterday's puzzle solution.

Hidato Sol. 2/25

9	8	7	43	44	45	49	48
10	4	5	6	42	50	46	47
11	13	3	15	51	41	40	39
12	2	14	16	52	28	38	
	1	19	17	27	53	29	37
62	20	18	25	26	30	54	36
61	21	22	57	24	55	31	35
60	59	58	23	56	32	33	34

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7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 Aussie croc (6)	
2 cross in the fruit shop (7)	
3 Irish actor Barry (7)	
4 2024 Olympics host (5)	
5 most wacky (8)	
6 legs, informally (4)	
7 Booker winner Bernardine (8)	

SA DAF LO IE OGH
GE PI TO FI AR
EST EV PA KE TAN
AN IS LT NS RIS

Yesterday's Answers: 1. ELEVATOR 2. CARAVAGGIO 3. WILLOW 4. BRAM 5. THERE 6. RIVERS 7. MILK 12/20

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Eisenkot Gets Chance to Form Govt in Israel After Tight Vote

Former commander of Israel's armed forces has six weeks to form a coalition government

Israeli election challenger Gadi Eisenkot will get the first attempt at forming a new government, putting him a step closer to ending Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's record tenure.

Eisenkot will be nominated on Sunday, according to a statement from President Isaac Herzog's office. He'll have up to six weeks to try to form a coalition that accounts for the majority of 120 parliamentary seats. Failure would mean the task likely reverts to Netanyahu, who for now continues to govern in a caretaker capacity.

While neither candidate's political camp won a clear parliamentary majority in the October 27 vote, Eisenkot's nomination was supported by a majority of parties. The centrist ex-general said he was already negotiating to cobble together what he called a "national emergency government" to oust Netanyahu, under whose hard-right coalition Israel has been mired in war and deepening international isolation.

"This is the top priority given the immense and fateful challenges, from within and without, facing Israel," Eisenkot said in a post on X.

Eisenkot's bloc secured 48 seats in the election, short of Netanyahu's 53. The challenger said he would be open to allying with other parties that agree to conditions including recognition of Israel as a Jewish state and of Hamas as a terrorist group.



A BIG CHALLENGE

A failure will likely revert the task back to Netanyahu, who at the moment continues to govern in caretaker capacity

That appeared to be directed mainly at two parties that cater to Israel's Arab minority, which surged to 19 seats. They have historically shunned or been excluded from governance, given their pro-Palestinian sympathies and waiver from national service. Their constituents complain of system discrimination that raises questions about the inclusiveness of Israeli democracy.

Netanyahu has alleged that foreign funding illicitly boosted Arab voter turnout. Election officials ordered investigations but still certified the vote tally.

In a video statement, Netanyahu accused Eisenkot of planning to set up a government with "terrorism supporters" and offered to join him in broad coalition instead. Eisenkot has called for an end to the career of the six-term prime minister, who failed to prevent the October 7, 2023, Hamas invasion and is under indictment on corruption charges that he denies.

Still, Eisenkot may reconsider if US President Donald Trump renews the military campaign against Iran, given Israel would be expected to offer support or risk further fracturing the already vulnerable US-Israeli partnership.

Barring that, an Eisenkot government would consign Netanyahu and his religious nationalist partners to the opposition. The challenger, who is untested in domestic politics and international diplomacy, has pledged to reverse the country's course, without giving details. He's echoed Netanyahu's rejection of a Palestinian state and warnings about a nuclear-armed Iran.

Eisenkot — a former commander of Israel's armed forces who lost a son and two nephews as soldiers in the Gaza war — will find allying with Arab parties that do not accept his conditions a tall order. The same goes for ultra-Orthodox Jewish parties which won a combined 13 seats, and want their constituents exempted from the draft.

Another option for Eisenkot could be forming a minority government with tacit protection from Arab or ultra-Orthodox parties in the opposition, which would decline to join in no-confidence motions as long as their demands are met. **Bloomberg**

Aramco's Riyadh Office Suffers Limited Damage After Attack

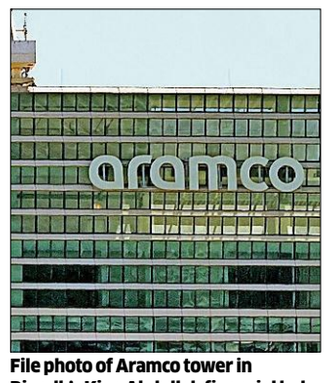
Attack by Houthis on Sunday adds to a series of strikes on Aramco infrastructure in recent weeks

Saudi Aramco offices in Riyadh came under attack on Sunday as the kingdom confronts a fresh wave of strikes from the Iran-backed Houthis in Yemen.

An administrative building of the Saudi Arabian state oil behemoth suffered limited damages due to falling shrapnel, according to the Ministry of Energy and state-backed Saudi Press Agency. There were no injuries or deaths, they said.

Aramco's main office in the Saudi capital is in King Abdullah Financial District, which has been under remote work orders for about a month.

Sunday's incident adds to a series of strikes on Aramco infrastructure in recent weeks, including on its headquarters in Dhahran and the Shaybah oil field in the Eastern Province.



File photo of Aramco tower in Riyadh's King Abdullah financial hub

It's also perhaps the most significant targeting of Riyadh since the Houthi militants struck the main airport there last month, killing more than a dozen people, injuring hundreds and snarling air traffic into and out of the kingdom.

The weekend's developments threaten to heap further pressure on Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman as he works to keep his multi-trillion dollar economic diversification plan on track while grappling with the fallout of near-daily Houthi attacks.

Saudi-led forces said on Sunday they intercepted ballistic and cruise missiles launched toward Riyadh and thwarted attacks in the south and east.

The events come with speculation mounting in the Middle East over the next developments in the US-Iran war and elections in Israel. Washington and Tehran are moving closer to a potential breakthrough in efforts to end the conflict after a monthslong stalemate, Bloomberg has reported. **Bloomberg**

'Anthropic Buys Power for AI Data Centres in $3.4b Deal'

Anthropic PBC has agreed to pay $3.4 billion for gas-fired generators for data centers, the *FT* reported, in what it described as the largest known single purchase of power-generation equipment by an AI lab.

The company bought commitments for 1.7 gigawatts of heavy-duty generators from San Antonio-based equipment supplier OnePWR Solutions in late September, without acquiring the company itself, according to the newspaper. Anthropic initially planned to buy power from OnePWR before instead taking over its Caterpillar Inc. generator orders, it added.

The purchase is the latest sign of AI labs pushing deeper into the energy industry and bypassing intermediaries in the race to secure scarce power equipment. **Bloomberg**

Iran Claims It has Lifted Self-imposed Restriction on Ballistic Missile Ranges

2,000-KM RESTRICTION

Tehran may seek to develop missiles capable of reaching more distant targets as fears of renewed war rise

Iran's Revolutionary Guard says it has lifted a self-imposed limit of 2,000 kilometers (1,200 miles) on the range of its ballistic missiles, suggesting the country may seek to develop missiles capable of reaching more distant targets as fears of renewed all-out war rise.

Meanwhile, airstrikes near Yemen's capital killed at least 27 people, according to a spokesman for Yemen's Houthi-run Health Ministry. The comments by the spokesman of Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard came days after the country's supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khomeini, warned that "any kind and level of threat" from the US or Israel would face a response without geographic limits.

Asked at a Tehran news conference about the limit on missile ranges, General Hossein Mohebbi said: "That restriction has been lifted for us."

Iran is not known to have missiles that can go beyond the 2,000-kilometer (1,200-mile) limit. However, US officials have said technology from Iran's space programME can be repurposed to build intercontinental ballistic missiles.

US Central Command said late Saturday it disabled a St. Kitts-flagged ship after it ignored multiple warnings and attempted to leave the region after visiting an Iranian port.

US forces have been enforcing a naval blockade on Iran for months in and around the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial strategic waterway for global shipping, including of oil.

Iran established a chokehold on the strait at the beginning of the war, and has claimed attacks on tankers. On Saturday night, the Iranian military said two tankers in the area had hit mines and caught fire.

The US says its blockade had redirected 144 commercial vessels through the end of October. **AP**

MILLER MAY KEEP REPUBLICANS IN LINE

Trump Turns to Loyalist Stephen Miller for a More Combative Final 2 Years

West Palm Beach, Florida | Washington: President Donald Trump's decision to elevate loyalist Stephen Miller to run his White House indicates that he plans to ramp up confrontation in his final two years in office and block outside political and economic pressures, Trump administration officials and other Republicans say.

Voters delivered a historic rebuke to Republicans in Tuesday's midterm election, but with Miller as White House chief of staff, the Trump administration is expected to continue its aggressive immigration crackdown, amplify cultural conflicts and give no ground to a Democratic-controlled Congress, say officials and experts who spoke to Reuters. They say wavering Republicans will face increased pressure to stay in line, while businesses may have a harder time making their case to the White House.

"This signals the administration is going to have a fighting-from-a-bunker approach the last two years," said Dan Eberhart, a Trump donor and energy executive.



Stephen Miller

Although Trump has said he can work with Democrats, he has shown a feisty approach since the midterm election results became clear.

Miller, 41, marks a sharp contrast with outgoing chief of staff Susie Wiles, a former lobbyist who ran Trump's 2024 presidential campaign. Wiles lacked significant Washington experience but was seen as a deft manager of competing interests. Miller, by contrast, is regarded by allies and foes alike as a combative ideologue with a deep knowledge of the levers of power and an unswerving loyalty to Trump. **Reuters**

AFP



Mourners place flowers and candles at a makeshift memorial for the victims in Krakow on Sunday

Poles Mourn Mass Killing, Attacker Said to Have Far-right Views

Krakow: Poland began two days of national mourning on Sunday, after a 24-year-old man with far-right views drove into a busy central square in Krakow and opened fire, killing six people and wounding 15 others before police shot and wounded him.

The attack, which Poland's defence minister described as an "act of terror," happened on Saturday in Main Square, which is in the heart of Krakow's Old Town and is a major tourist hub in the country's second-largest city.

The square remained partially closed on Sunday morning as authorities continued their investigation. St. Mary's Trumpet Call, a traditional five-note melody played every hour from the highest tower of St Mary's Basilica on the Main Square, was paused, first time since World War II. **AP**

Sports: World Play

VITALS

An Wins Korea Open for 11th Badminton Title of the Year

Badminton world number one An Se-young said she was "very proud" of her achievements after winning an incredible 11th title of the year at her home Korea Open on Sunday. The 24-year-old beat Japan's Akane Yamaguchi 21-12, 15-21, 21-16 in the final in Yeosu to extend an unbeaten run that stretches back to March. An has been head and shoulders above the rest of the competition this year but she said she still had to be on her guard against world number two Yamaguchi. "She's a player who can always keep the score close so I tried to keep the intensity up all the way until the end," An told the Badminton World Federation. "When the match was over, I was very proud of myself. It felt a bit different because it's my home tournament." It was An's 11th straight win over Yamaguchi. **AFP**

Karamoko-Waltert Too Strong for Indians in Chennai Open Final

India's Vaishnavi Adkar and Rutuja Bhosale had to settle for a runners-up finish at the WTA 250 Chennai Open after going down 2-6 0-6 to the Swiss combination of Simona Waltert and Naima Karamoko in a one-sided women's doubles final here Sunday. The Indian pair struggled to match the quality and intensity of their opponents, with Karamoko almost impregnable at the net and Waltert providing solid support from the baseline to seal the title in convincing fashion. Karamoko's quick hands, sharp anticipation and ability to finish points at the net made life difficult for the Indians, who also hurt their chances with a string of unforced errors and an inability to convert crucial points in closely-contested games. The Swiss pair made an aggressive start, with Waltert striking confidently from the baseline, particularly with her backhand, while Karamoko dominated the exchanges at the net. The Indian pair found themselves under further pressure as the Swiss players increasingly moved forward to take control of the exchanges. **PTI**

Messi Makes History, Again!

Two Seasons, Two MLS Boots

Argentine legend becomes first player in the league to win consecutive titles with 26 goals

Inter Miami's Lionel Messi won his second consecutive MLS Golden Boot award on Saturday after the defending champions took second place in the Eastern Conference with a wasteful 3-3 draw against Charlotte on the final day of the regular season.

The Argentine superstar did not score but set up the first two goals at Miami's Nu Stadium, both from corners, to help procure his club a home-field advantage for the first two playoff rounds.

Messi's 26 goals this season were enough to make him the first back-to-back MLS Golden Boot award winner. Petar Musa of Dallas was second on 22, not scoring in his club's 3-1 home victory over Colorado.

Ian Fray, Luis Suarez and Rodrigo De Paul racked up three first-half strikes for Inter Miami before Liel Abada's brace soon after the break sparked a comeback sealed by Rodolfo Aloko's late strike.



Runaway overall leaders Nashville broke the all-time MLS points record for a season with a whopping 77 after beating Cincinnati 2-0. At 23-3 with eight drawn, Nashville won the East and broke the mark of 74 points set by Miami in 2024.

Miami finished second in the East on 60 points as third-place New England failed to take advantage of Inter's draw with a surprise 1-0 loss at Orlando to end on 58.

Messi's men will face Columbus to begin the MLS playoffs. Other East matchups send New England against Philadelphia, Charlotte against Chicago and top seed Nashville against the wild-card winner, Orlando or Cincinnati.

Columbus took advantage of the Cincinnati loss with a 4-3 victory at Chicago to finish seventh and avoid the wild card round.

At Miami, Messi's 14th-minute corner fell unexpectedly to Charlotte's Luca de la Torre, who spooned it up for Fray to open the scoring.

Another Messi corner in the 33rd minute found Suarez wide open at the near post. The Uruguayan glanced in his header for 2-0.

De Paul made it three before halftime, but Abada pulled back a goal for the visitors early and bagged a second in the 55th minute.

In the 90th, Aloko bagged the equalizer, responding first to the ball as Smalls's shot ricocheted off the post.

A visibly frustrated Messi hit the post in stoppage time before Aloko came inches from bagging an unlikely winner with a thunderous shot into the outside netting. — **AFP**

REUTERS

Former Youngest Champion Fittipaldi Hails Antonelli's Rise

Sao Paulo: Emerson Fittipaldi said the emergence of increasingly younger title winners was a natural progression of the sport, with drivers now beginning their careers much earlier than previous generations, as he hailed Mercedes' 20-year-old world champion Kimi Antonelli.

Brazilian Fittipaldi became the sport's youngest world champion aged 25 in 1972 and held that record until a then 24-year-old Fernando Alonso eclipsed it in 2005.

After Antonelli's success with Mercedes this season, Fittipaldi no longer ranks among the five youngest title winners, a shift he said reflects how modern athletes begin competing at elite levels from early childhood.

"I think it's great to see the new generation arriving, as in every sport at the international level," the 79-year-old Fittipaldi told Reuters at Interlagos on Saturday ahead of the Sao Paulo Grand Prix.

"Today, young people start at six, five or four years old."

Antonelli was introduced to go-karting when he was aged five by his father and competed in Formula Two before making his F1 debut last year. He now heads the list of youngest champions ahead of Sebastian Vettel, Lewis Hamilton, Alonso and Max Verstappen.

The Brazilian's own rise was markedly different. Fittipaldi was 17 when he began go-karting and became Formula One world champion eight years later, one of the sport's most meteoric ascents.



Kimi Antonelli GETTY IMAGES

For the double champion, who won his titles in 1972 and 1974 for Lotus and McLaren respectively, Antonelli's achievement is evidence not only of changing times but also of exceptional talent.

"He has already shown maturity and performed very well under pressure," he said, pointing to the Italian's victory at his home race at Monza after starting 19th on the grid as proof of his composure.

Antonelli also singled out the race as one of the defining moments of his championship-winning campaign.

"Because after taking the engine penalty, obviously starting from the back, I did not expect such a result. And when I got that, I was like, 'okay, now we just, no matter what, we've got to go and win this'," he told Reuters this week. — **Reuters**

Hodge's Ton Puts Windies in Control vs Bangladesh

Sylhet (Bangladesh): Kavem Hodge struck 140 not out as West Indies established control in the second and final cricket Test against Bangladesh on Sunday in its quest to sweep the series.

Complemented by half-centuries from Kevin Wickham (78) and opener Brandon King (61), Hodge steered West Indies to 345-3, extending the lead to 315 runs at stumps on the fourth day.

Bangladesh bowlers rarely troubled the West Indies' batters after the visitors resumed at 7 for no loss.

King and Joshua Da Silva added 85 runs for the opening stand, which was only broken when left-arm spinner Taijul Islam produced a gem to trap Da Silva leg-before for 36. King went on to score his sixth fifty and looked untroubled but a rash shot against offspinner Mehidy Hasan Miraz cost him his wicket, leaving West Indies at 119-2.

Two wickets in quick succession from their spinners gave Bangladesh a glimmer of hope but Wickham and Hodge used their feet well to sweep the spin bowlers' efforts with precision, gradually establishing full control of the game.



Kavem Hodge AFP

Wickham raised his second fifty in the game off 68 balls on his debut test, cracking a boundary through extra cover. Unlike the first innings when he was out for 61, Wickham appeared set for a hundred but was dismissed in casual fashion, chipping the ball straight to bowler Taijul on 78. Taijul ended the day with 2-118.

Hodge kept attacking the bowlers and reached his third century from 142 balls, sweeping Taijul to square leg for a single.

Amir Jangoo, who hit a century in the first innings to help West Indies put up 356, was batting on 20 with Hodge when the game was called off for the day due to bad light. — **AP**

New Pak Test Squad Ready to Fight Lanka, says Azam

Captain Babar Azam hopes an overhauled Pakistan can make a fresh start in the first Test against Sri Lanka that begins in Rawalpindi on Monday after their disastrous series against England.

The two-match series is Pakistan's first since their 3-0 whitewash in England, where seven players were sent home after the second Test.

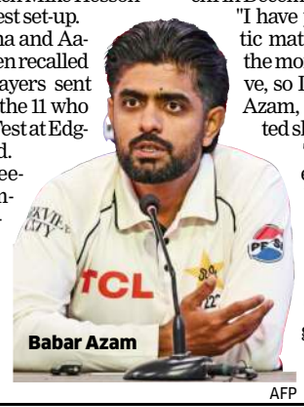
Head coach Sarfaraz Ahmed and bowling coach Umar Gul were also sacked in a September overhaul, with white-ball coach Mike Hesson brought in to the Test set-up.

Only Salman Agha and Aamer Jamal have been recalled from the seven players sent home, with five of the 11 who played in the final Test at Edgbaston also dropped.

Senior wicketkeeper-batter Mohammad Rizwan, former skipper Shan Masood and the spin duo of Sajid Khan and Noman Ali all missed out.

Batters Mohammad Taha, Saad Baig, Tayyab Arif and Sameer Minhas, along with pace bowlers Saqib Khan and Ali Shabbir, were all included for the first time.

"During the England series we had planned to give new players a chance, so I am ready to fight with these young players," Azam said on Sunday. He also hopes to revive his batting form after 40 Test innings without a century, his last Test ton coming against New Zealand in Karachi in December 2022.



Babar Azam AFP

"I have played a few domestic matches and think that the more I play I will improve, so I am confident," said Azam, who was reappointed skipper in July.

The two-match series is part of the World Test Championship's fourth cycle, with Pakistan ninth and last and Sri Lanka seventh. The second Test begins in Lahore on November 17. — **AFP**

Pakistan Beat India by 3 Wickets in U-19 Asia Cup

Al Amerat (Oman): Pakistan defeated India by three wickets in their men's U-19 Asia Cup match here on Sunday.

India were bowled out for a modest 208 and Pakistan, after a top-order wobble, managed to complete the chase with Hamza Zahoor taking the team home with an excellent, unbeaten 100 off 108 balls after coming in to bat at number seven.

Earlier, Arjun Rajput top-scored for India with an aggressive 107 off 85 balls, and his knock included 11 fours and five sixes. Both Aryavir Sehwag (22) and Anvay Dravid (10) were dismissed cheaply.

Manal Chauhan picked up 3/32 in 10 overs for India.

BRIEF SCORES:

India U-19: 208 in 46.3 overs (Arjun Rajput 107, Ali Raza 3/37).

Pakistan U-19: 209/7 in 48.1 overs (Hamza Zahoor 100 not out; Manal Chauhan 3/32). — **PTI**